

POLICE FREEZE OVER RS 4 CRORE

Ex-PM IK Gujral’s son duped of Rs 7.8 crore in cyber fraud

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Former Rajya Sabha MP Naresh Gujral was allegedly duped of Rs 7.8 crore after cyber fraudsters impersonated him on a messaging app and tricked his company’s chief financial officer into transferring funds to multiple bank accounts, police said on Thursday.

Naresh, 78, is the son of the late I K Gujral, who served as India’s 12th prime minister from 1997 to 1998.

According to the police, the fraud occurred between June 12 and June 16. The scammers allegedly created an account on an online messaging platform using Gujral’s display picture to impersonate him.

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CLOSER LOOK

» They sent messages instructing one of his employees to transfer funds via Real-Time Gross Settlement (RTGS) to a specified bank account for what appeared to be urgent business-related purposes

» Believing the instructions were legitimate, the employee, who had been given financial access by Gujral, executed four separate RTGS transactions over the course of four days, resulting in a loss of Rs 7.8 crore, the police said

quently distributed to around 30 to 40 accounts before being moved through multiple additional mule accounts in an apparent attempt to conceal the money trail, police said.

Cyber investigators are now tracking the movement of funds and identifying the beneficiaries of the transactions.

Gujral said swift reporting of the fraud helped authorities freeze a substantial portion of the stolen amount.

“My company and our CFO were victims of the fraud. I was and am out of town. However, do mention that since we reported the crime quickly to the cybercrime department, they helped us to recover more than 70 per cent of the amount, and they are hoping to recover more,” he said.

Police said efforts are underway to trace the remaining funds and arrest those involved in the cyber fraud.

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The fraud was uncovered on June 16 when the transac-

tions came to the attention of Gujral’s daughter, who immediately verified the situation with her father and discovered that he had never issued any such directions. “On the complaint of Naresh Gujral, an FIR has been registered on 16.06.2026. Immediate further action was taken, and Rs 4.28 crore out of the total defrauded amount of Rs 7.68 crore has

been marked as a lien/hold in various banks. Efforts are being made to apprehend the persons involved in the fraud,” a senior police officer said. Investigators said the money was first routed into four bank accounts in Maharashtra and Andhra Pradesh, adding that between Rs 1 crore and Rs 2 crore was transferred to these accounts each. The funds were subse-

Man accused of kidnapping, raping minor girl apprehended after 17 yrs

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: A 42-year-old man, who had been on the run for 17 years after being accused of kidnapping and raping a minor girl here, was arrested from Uttar Pradesh’s Bijnor, a police officer said on Thursday.

The accused, identified as Irshad Ahmed alias Sonu, was a proclaimed offender carrying a reward of Rs 25,000 and had allegedly evaded arrest since 2009 before fleeing to Kuwait, where he lived and worked as a tailor for several years, he said.

“The case was registered at Bindapur police station in Delhi on April 9, 2009. The complainant, who ran a boutique, had alleged that Ahmed, then employed as a tailor at the establishment, kidnapped her 17-year-old daughter with the intention of marrying her and sexually assaulted her,” said the officer.

Soon after the alleged crime, the accused disappeared and continuously evaded arrest despite repeated efforts by the

TAKEAWAYS

» ‘The case was registered at Bindapur PS in Delhi on April 9, 2009. The complainant, who ran a boutique, had alleged that Ahmed, then employed as a tailor at the establishment, kidnapped her 17-year-old daughter with the intention of marrying her and sexually assaulted her,’ said the officer

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» On May 25, 2011, a court declared Ahmed a proclaimed offender after it was informed that he remained untraceable.

police to nab him. He was later learnt to have gotten married to another woman while he was still on the run, the officer said.

On May 25, 2011, a Delhi court declared Ahmed a proclaimed offender after it was informed that he remained

untraceable.

“The crime branch was assigned the task of tracing and apprehending Ahmed. A team revisited old records and developed fresh leads. During the course of the investigation, police learnt that Ahmed

had obtained a passport from Chandigarh while he was absconding and left for Kuwait in 2011,” the officer added.

During investigation, police found that Ahmed had virtually settled in the Gulf nation and worked as a tailor in a boutique. He allegedly remarried during his stay abroad, while his family continued to reside in his native village in Bijnor.

Police found that he rarely visited India and generally arrived only for important family occasions, making his apprehension particularly challenging.

“Recently, the team received specific information that the accused had arrived at his native village on June 3 to attend a family function and was likely to return to Kuwait by the end of the month. Acting on the input, the police team laid a trap and apprehended him on June 16, bringing to an end a 17-year-long manhunt,” the officer said.

Further legal proceedings are underway, he added.

Five infants rescued, 13 caught in major child trafficking bust

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police has busted an inter-state child trafficking syndicate operating across multiple states, arresting 13 people -- including alleged traffickers, mediators, buyers and a hospital owner -- while rescuing five infants, an official said on Thursday.

The racket was unearthed following a decoy operation near RK Ashram Metro Station in Paharganj on June 5, he said. Police caught three accused: Jyoti alias Kamlesh (37), Shalu (43) and Lalit while they were allegedly attempting to sell a newborn baby boy, aged about four to five days, to decoy customers.

The official said after the infant was rescued and Rs 20,000 paid as token money by the decoy buyers was recovered, police registered a case at Paharganj police station under relevant provisions of the BNS and the Juvenile Justice Act.

Investigation revealed that the accused were part of an child trafficking network that procured infants from different



states and sold them to childless couples for lakhs of rupees, police said.

According to investigators, Jyoti was a key coordinator of the syndicate and sourced newborns through intermediaries, including an accused, Sayabhai Ghamar alias Kalia, who allegedly supplied infants from Rajasthan and Gujarat.

Based on disclosures made by the arrested accused, police later apprehended Pratibha, a freelance lab technician associated with a private hospital, and Vipin, a driver who allegedly facilitated the transportation of infants and syndicate members. Police recovered Rs 2.92 lakh cash from them, allegedly intended for purchasing a newborn child.

Police said another accused, Omwati, a domestic worker from Gurugram, allegedly acted as a mediator and arranged infants for the trafficking network. Investigators found the alleged involvement of Dr Viveki, owner of Heera Multi Speciality Hospital in Begampur, who facilitated illegal adoptions by sheltering trafficked infants at the facility, identifying prospective buyers among childless couples seeking fertility treatment and arranging fabricated medical and birth-related documents to establish false parentage.

The probe found that the syndicate operated through a network of suppliers, transporters, facilitators and buyers spread across Delhi, Haryana, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Gujarat. Police rescued four more infants from Haryana and Madhya Pradesh, taking the total to five, and arrested the syndicate’s alleged key supplier in Gujarat. Investigators suspect the babies were trafficked across states using forged documents and illegal adoption arrangements.

Delhi universities climb in QS World Rankings

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: Delhi’s leading higher education institutions have strengthened their global standing in the QS World University Rankings (QSWUR) 2027, reflecting rising academic influence, research output and international recognition.

At the forefront, IIT Delhi emerged as the city’s top-ranked institution, securing the 118th global position an improvement of five places from last year and equaling the highest ranking ever achieved by an Indian institution in QS history.

The institute’s performance was driven by gains across key indicators. Employer Reputation improved to 39th globally, highlighting stronger confidence among recruiters in the employability and preparedness of IIT Delhi graduates. Significant improvements were also recorded in Employment Outcomes and Citations per Faculty, reflecting growing



“IIT Delhi emerged as the city’s top-ranked institution, securing the 118th global position”

research impact and academic quality.

Prof. Somnath Baidya Roy, Dean (Planning) and Head of Ranking Cell, said the institution remains committed to providing globally competitive yet affordable education while expanding research and international engagement.

Other Delhi universities also recorded notable progress.

The University of Delhi improved to 322nd globally from 328 last year, maintaining its position as the highest-ranked university category institution in the country and strengthening its international academic profile.

Jamia Millia Islamia achieved its highest-ever QS ranking, jumping more than 75 places to reach 686 globally and entering the top 20 institutions nationally. The rise was attributed to stronger research performance, improved employability and increasing global visibility.

Jawaharlal Nehru University also registered a modest improvement, moving up to 555th globally.

The latest rankings indicate an evolving academic landscape in Delhi, where universities are increasingly gaining recognition through research excellence, institutional reform and stronger global engagement.

Rapido rider held for wife’s murder

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE

NEW DELHI: Delhi Police have arrested a 30-year-old Rapido rider for allegedly murdering his wife in Shahdara’s Kailash Nagar area after suspecting her of having an extra-marital relationship.

The accused, identified as Khalid Navi, allegedly slit the throat of his wife, Rukshar (30), on June 13 before fleeing the city. Police received a PCR call about the incident and

Navi was nabbed in Mumbai on June 16

found the woman dead at their residence in Chandrapuri. A blood-stained knife, suspected to be the murder weapon, was recovered from the scene.

A case was registered under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, and an investigation was launched. Police examined CCTV footage, recorded statements of family

members and witnesses, and found that the accused had switched off his phone and left no digital trail.

Following searches across Delhi, Uttar Pradesh, Karnataka, Mumbai and Goa, Navi was traced and arrested in Mumbai on June 16. During questioning, he allegedly confessed to killing his wife during an argument. Police said he had previously been arrested six times under preventive provisions of the law.

Admission guidance at Miranda

4-day outreach programme draws strong response

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: As undergraduate admission season gathers pace, Miranda House has launched a four-day Open House programme aimed at guiding prospective students and their families through the admission process and campus experience.

The sessions, scheduled for June 17, 18, 19 and 22, have attracted significant interest, with more than 700 students and parents registering and nearly 100 visiting the campus on the opening day.

The initiative offers aspirants detailed information on admissions, academic programmes, campus life and career prospects. Visitors are being taken on guided tours of classrooms, laboratories, libraries and sports facilities while also participating in interactive sessions with the Principal, faculty members and administrative officials.

Discussions have focused on CUET-based admissions, Delhi University’s Common Seat Allocation System (CSAS), preference filling and course selection.

The development comes amid growing debate over the Common

KEY POINTS

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University Entrance Test (CUET). A Parliamentary Standing Committee on Education, chaired by Rajya Sabha MP Digvijaya Singh, has raised concerns over the examination’s heavy dependence on multiple-choice questions.

The committee argued that subjects in humanities and social sciences require analytical reasoning and original expression, which objective assessments may not fully capture. While recognising CUET’s role in creating a common admission platform, the panel recommended reforms to make the system more inclusive and academically comprehensive.

Man nabbed for attacking cops

NEW DELHI: The Crime Branch of Delhi Police has arrested a 24-year-old man wanted for allegedly assaulting police personnel and possessing an illegal firearm, officials said.

The accused, identified as Farman, a resident of Shalimar Garden in Ghaziabad, Uttar Pradesh, was apprehended following an intelligence-led operation by the Western Range-I unit of the Crime Branch.

Police said Farman was wanted in a case registered at Kotwali Police Station under provisions of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita and the Arms Act. The case dates back to February 4, when

a police patrol team near the Iron Bridge signalled a motorcycle to stop during routine checking.

According to investigators, Farman and his associate allegedly threatened police personnel with an illegal pistol, assaulted them and attempted to flee. While the co-accused was arrested at the spot, Farman escaped.

Acting on a tip-off, police traced him through technical surveillance and analysis of his social media activity. He was arrested near the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh border after allegedly trying to evade capture.

Delhi approves policy to count Census duty as official service period for guest teachers

Policy brings Census work on par with election, BLO duties

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Delhi Education Minister Ashish Sood approved a policy under which the period spent by guest teachers on Census duty will be treated as official service, ensuring that they do not lose salary, teaching experience or service benefits while carrying out the government-assigned task. The decision, announced by the Directorate of Education (DoE), aims to bring uniformity in the treatment of government and statutory duties assigned to the guest teachers and ensure that time spent on Census work is counted as regular working days.

According to a statement, the period of deployment on Census operations will be added to a guest

teacher’s total working days and teaching experience, and will be reflected in experience certificates used for career progression.

Sood said the guest teachers play an important role in nation-building and should not be disadvantaged for undertaking responsibilities assigned by the government.

“Guest Teachers are not merely educators; they are partners in nation-building. When the government entrusts them with important national responsibilities like the Census, they should not be penalised for serving the country. “This decision ensures that every day spent in public service receives due recognition and respect,” he said.

The move is intended to safeguard the professional interests of thousands of

guest teachers and ensure that those performing important national and statutory duties do not suffer any loss of service benefits, experience or remuneration, the statement said. Under the policy, guest teachers deployed for Census work will continue to receive their daily wages and regular remuneration for the period of deployment.

It said Census duty would now be treated on par with other public-interest assignments such as election duty, work as booth level officers (BLOs) and duties performed during COVID-19 relief operations. The proposal would ensure that the guest teachers are not forced to choose between fulfilling national responsibilities and protecting their professional interests, it added.



Delhi starts 3-day Jan Kalyan Shivir drive across 42 venues

Drive offers access to Ayushman Cards, pensions, Aadhaar and other services

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a major outreach exercise aimed at taking governance beyond government offices, the Delhi government on Thursday launched Jan Kalyan Shivirs at 42 locations across the capital, enabling residents to access a host of Central and Delhi government welfare schemes under one roof. The three-day initiative, running from June 18 to June 20, seeks to eliminate bureaucratic hurdles and ensure that no eligible beneficiary is left behind.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta inaugurated the flagship camp at the MCD Community Hall in Sandesh Vihar, Shalimar Bagh, describing the initiative as a step towards delivering “service, convenience and solutions” directly to citizens.

“Earlier, people had to visit different offices to avail the benefits of various schemes. However, with the double-engine government and a triple-engine system dedicated to



public service, the government is now reaching people at their doorstep,” Gupta said.

Emphasising inclusive welfare delivery, she added, “The government’s effort is to ensure that no eligible person is deprived of the benefits of any scheme and that government services reach the last person.”

The camps, organised as part of the celebrations marking 12 years of the Narendra Modi-led Central government,

offer assistance for services including Ayushman Cards, ration cards, Aadhaar registration, e-Shram cards, Jan Dhan accounts, PM SVANidhi, PM Surya Ghar Yojana, property tax-related services, MSME loans, caste and income certificates, pension updates and social welfare schemes.

PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh, who inaugurated a camp at Bengali Market, said, “Our effort

HIGHLIGHTS

» CM: ‘The government’s effort is to ensure that no eligible person is deprived of the benefits of any scheme and that government services reach the last person’

» ‘When governance reaches the doorstep of every citizen, welfare transforms into empowerment’: Vijender Gupta

citizen, welfare transforms into empowerment and public service becomes a lived reality,” he remarked.

Health and Transport Minister Dr Pankaj Kumar Singh said, “Every citizen should receive the services they are entitled to without having to run from office to office. The Delhi Government is committed to delivering welfare services at citizens’ doorsteps through these Jan Kalyan Shivirs.” Cabinet Minister Manjinder Singh Sirsa echoed the sentiment, stating, “The government’s objective is to ensure that no citizen has to make unnecessary visits to government offices for essential services and schemes. Through Jan Kalyan Shivirs, the government is reaching citizens directly at their doorstep.”

The Delhi government has appealed to residents to visit their nearest camp before the initiative concludes on June 20 and avail themselves of the welfare benefits on offer.

Delhi Assembly forms over 30 committees for 2026-27

AIMAN FATIMA

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Legislative Assembly has constituted more than 30 House and Department-Related Standing Committees for the legislative year 2026-27, assigning lawmakers from both the ruling BJP and Opposition parties to key oversight roles aimed at strengthening accountability and improving legislative scrutiny.

Announcing the new panels, Assembly Speaker Vijender Gupta said the committees would play a crucial role in enhancing the effectiveness of the legislature and ensuring that issues concerning public welfare receive detailed examination.

“These Committees will further strengthen the efficiency and accountability of the Assembly, while ensuring effective oversight of matters concerning public welfare,” Gupta said. He added that the committees were expected to make “meaningful recommendations” and contribute towards addressing “the aspirations and concerns of the citizens of the National Capital Territory of Delhi.”



The Speaker will continue to chair several influential panels, including the Business Advisory Committee, Committee on Private Members’ Bills and Resolutions, Rules Committee, General Purposes Committee and Library Committee. Deputy Speaker Mohan Singh Bisht will head the Committees on Government Assurances, Questions and References, and Peace and Harmony.

Among the notable appointments, BJP MLA Manoj Kumar Shokeen has been named Chairperson of the Committee on Petitions, while AAP leader Gopal Rai will head the Committee on Papers Laid on the Table. Poonam Sharma will chair the Committee on Women and Child Welfare, and Tarvin-

der Singh Marwah will lead the Committee on Welfare of Minorities.

The Assembly also announced the constitution of several subject-specific standing committees. Umang Bajaj will head the Department-Related Standing Committee on Education, Neelam Pahalan will chair the Welfare Committee, Sanjay Goyal will oversee the Health Committee, Shyam Sharma will lead the Development Committee, and Sandeep Sehrawat will head the Committee on Public Utilities and Civic Amenities.

Ravinder Singh Negi has been appointed Chairperson of the Department-Related Standing Committee on Finance and Transport, while Chandan Kumar Chaudhry will preside over the Administrative Matters Committee.

The newly constituted committees are expected to examine policy implementation, review departmental functioning, scrutinise government assurances and make recommendations to improve governance, reinforcing the Assembly’s role as a key instrument of democratic accountability in the national capital.

Delhi opens CWSN admissions in pvt schools

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The online admission process for Children With Special Needs (CWSN) seeking admission to entry-level classes in private schools under the Economically Weaker Section (EWS), Disadvantaged Group (DG) and CWSN quota has begun, with applications open till June 30, officials said.

According to the Directorate of Education (DoE), admissions are being conducted for pre-school, pre-primary and Class 1 in private unaided recognised schools, excluding minority institutions, under the Right to Education Act and Delhi School Education Rules. Seats for children with disabilities will be reserved within the 25 per cent EWS and DG quota. Applicants under the CWSN category are not required to submit an income certificate.

Admissions will be finalised through a computerised draw of lots. Candidates must possess a valid disability certificate issued by a government hospital. The DoE said only one application can be submitted for each child.

Delhi to host Hindi Diwas contests across government depts

NEW DELHI: Delhi government has announced a series of competitions for government employees and officials as part of the Hindi Diwas celebrations in September.

According to a circular issued on June 16 by the Art, Culture and Language Department, the competitions will be organised to encourage greater use of Hindi in official work and to promote the language among employees working in various departments, autonomous bodies and institutions under the Delhi government.

The competitions will be held from September 14 to 18, it stated.

The schedule includes a Hindi essay writing competi-

Delhi govt gives Rs 5 lakh to man who saved lives in Malviya Nagar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Chief Minister Rekha Gupta has announced an immediate ex-gratia assistance of Rs.5 lakh for Rohit Mukhiya, who suffered serious injuries while rescuing others during the June 3 fire at a restaurant in Malviya Nagar. The Delhi government has also assured that it will bear the entire cost of his treatment until his full recovery.

Calling Rohit’s actions an example of extraordinary courage and humanity, the Chief Minister wrote a heartfelt letter to him and his family, wishing him a speedy recovery.

“Rohit’s sense of duty and compassion in the face of adversity is a source of inspiration for many,” Gupta said, adding that courageous citizens like him strengthen society’s



faith in humanity.

On the Chief Minister’s directions, the West Delhi District Magistrate visited Rohit’s residence in Khidki Extension

and handed over a cheque of Rs.5 lakh to his family. Officials assured them that the government would extend all possible assistance during his treatment.

Rohit, who worked in the kitchen of the Hauz Rani restaurant where the fire broke out, first rushed to rescue two colleagues trapped on the first floor. With flames and thick smoke blocking escape routes, he broke a window using a bathroom bucket to create an exit, ensuring his co-workers escaped safely before jumping himself. He sustained severe injuries in the process.

“The Delhi Government stands firmly with him and will continue to provide every possible assistance until he makes a full recovery,” the Chief Minister said, directing doctors and officials to ensure there is no shortcoming in his treatment.

Delhi govt to arrange cooling zones for NEET parents at 97 exam centres: CM Rekha Gupta

NEW DELHI: In a first-of-its-kind initiative, the Delhi government has announced special arrangements for parents accompanying candidates appearing for the National Eligibility cum Entrance Test (NEET) on June 21, with cooling zones to be set up outside all 97 examination centres across the capital.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said the move recognises the often-overlooked challenges faced by parents waiting outside examination venues for hours in peak summer conditions.

“Special arrangements for parents to rest and wait during the examination are being made for the first time. It is our responsibility to respect every student and every parent,” Gupta said.

According to the Chief



Minister, Delhi has 97 NEET examination centres this year, including 69 government schools and 28 Kendriya Vidyalayas. District administrations have been directed to establish cooling zones near each centre with seating facilities and relief measures.

The waiting areas will provide clean drinking water, shikanji, ORS, tea and first-aid support to parents and family

members accompanying candidates. The initiative aims to shield them from the scorching heat while ensuring a more comfortable examination-day experience.

“Every year, millions of families arrive at examination centres carrying dreams for their children’s future. Yet the anxiety, heat and inconvenience faced by parents often go unnoticed,” Gupta

said, adding that the government wanted to address this “human aspect” of competitive examinations.

She noted that in previous years, parents were often forced to wait under trees, in parks or wander around markets due to the lack of proper facilities outside centres. “This situation will now change,” she said.

The Chief Minister said the objective was not merely to conduct examinations smoothly but to improve the overall experience for everyone involved. “When parents are comfortable and free from anxiety, it has a positive impact on students as well,” she added.

The initiative comes amid Delhi’s broader heat-relief measures, which include 85 shade structures, 15 cooling zones and 13 mobile heat relief units operating across the city. **MP05T**

MCD Leader of House Yadav inspects Shastri Nagar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Leader of House in the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) and Standing Committee member Jai Bhagwan Yadav on Thursday inspected Shastri Nagar Ward and directed officials to undertake measures for improving sanitation, easing traffic move-

ment, and strengthening civic infrastructure.

During the visit, Yadav instructed officials to ensure roads are made pothole-free and remove encroachments affecting traffic and drainage systems. Stressing the need for strict enforcement, he said commercial establishments must keep goods within shop

‘MCD remains committed to achieving a clean and green Delhi in line with the vision of CM Gupta’

premises to prevent obstruction and waterlogging.

He said the MCD remains committed to achieving a clean and green Delhi in line with the vision of Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and added that financial constraints would not hinder park maintenance, road repairs, and toilet construction.

Officials were also directed to improve public toilet facilities, strengthen dust-control measures, refurbish waste transfer stations, and ensure scientific segregation of waste.

Yadav additionally inspected a subsidised community kitchen run by local councillor Manoj Kumar Jindal, where meals are served for ₹5, and praised the initiative as a model of public service.

QUOTA INTENDED TO RECOGNISE NATIONAL SERVICE L-G orders 20% quota for ex-Agniveers in recruitment of police constables, firemen

NEW DELHI: Delhi Lieutenant Governor (L-G) Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Thursday directed a 20 per cent reservation for former Agniveers in group ‘C’ posts of police constables, firemen, forest guards, jail warders and wildlife guards.

All concerned departments have a June 20 deadline to complete the necessary processes and amendments to recruitment rules, he said.

Sandhu reviewed the strategy for reservation benefits for former Agniveers (retired short service Army personnel) across various government departments and agencies in Delhi during a meeting with

the chief secretary, the Delhi Police Commissioner and other senior officers.

The L-G said in a post on X that this initiative is being implemented in accordance with the guiding vision of the Government of India. “To effectively harness the discipline, skills, and training of these young men and women,

directed the implementation of a 20 per cent reservation in direct recruitment to vacant Group ‘C’ posts, including police constables, firemen, jail warders, forest guards, and wildlife guards,” the LG said.

Group C posts are non-gazetted positions.

The L-G said recruitment will ensure equal opportunity and recognise former Agniveers’ service to the nation. He said the departments have further been empowered to deploy and utilise the specialised capabilities of these recruits in line with their operational requirements.



Agniveer scheme is the new recruitment system introduced by the Government of India for

the Indian Army, Navy, and Air Force. Under the scheme, eligible candidates are enrolled as Agniveers for a fixed period of four years.

Sandhu had proposed recruitments of former Agniveers to the Delhi Fire Service in a meeting held on June 8.

Lok Niwas officials said the L-G reaffirmed the government’s commitment to national service rendered by the Agniveers, and noted that seamlessly integrating these dedicated individuals into the civic framework will significantly augment the capital’s institutional resilience and boost the collective vision of a progressive ‘Viksit Dilli’.

MCD regularises 41 sanitation workers

Releases seniority list of 5,750 daily wagers

ANAMTA FATIMA

NEW DELHI: In a move aimed at strengthening job security and welfare measures for sanitation workers, the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) on Thursday distributed regularisation letters to sanitation employees and released the seniority list of 5,750 daily wage workers at a ceremony held at the Civic Centre.

The event was attended by Union Minister of State and Delhi BJP President Harsh Malhotra, Delhi Mayor Pravesh Wahi, senior MCD officials and elected representatives.

Addressing the gathering, Malhotra said that 41 sanitation workers were regularised in the current phase and announced that approximately 9,345 more daily wage sanitation workers would be regularised in a phased manner over the next year.

He stated that the objective was to ensure that no sanitation worker in the MCD remains on temporary employment.

During the programme, appointment letters were also handed over on compassionate grounds to the dependents



of 109 deceased sanitation workers.

Malhotra said sanitation workers play a vital role in maintaining public health and cleanliness across the capital and added that regularisation would provide employment stability, social security and access to healthcare benefits.

Mayor Pravesh Wahi said the initiative reflected recognition of the contribution of sanitation workers and reiterated that the civic body would continue efforts toward phased regularisation of temporary staff.

DEMS Committee Chairman Sandeep Kapoor described sanitation workers as essential contributors to the city’s public health system.

'BOTH LEADERS HELD WIDE-RANGING TALKS'

Modi, Trump direct officials to swiftly finalise trade pact: Foreign Secy Misri

PARIS: Trade was a major subject of discussion between Prime Minister Narendra Modi and US President Donald Trump, with both leaders directing their negotiators to finalise the proposed trade pact at the earliest, Foreign Secretary Vikram Misri said on Thursday.

Misri's comments came a day after Modi and Trump held wide-ranging talks for the first time in 16 months on the margins of the G7 Summit in an attempt to rebuild the strained bilateral ties.

"There were some important and urgent issues that needed to be discussed yesterday, notably the trade agreement, which is something that has created a certain amount of uncertainty over the past year or so between the two countries," the foreign secretary said.

"And it was important that we move forward to some kind of certainty on these issues," he said at a media briefing.

Misri said significant progress has been made on the con-



Prime Minister Narendra Modi, US President Donald Trump and US Ambassador to India Sergio Gor during a meeting on the sidelines of the G7 Summit, in France

clusion of the interim trade pact and that US Trade Representative, Jamieson Greer, will be visiting India next week to take forward the discussions.

"With the United States, we have made significant progress already on the conclusion of an interim free trade agreement. We are in the final stages of concluding that agreement," he said.

"In the bilateral meeting between the Prime Minister

and President Donald Trump in Evian, this was a major subject of discussion. Both leaders once again gave instructions for this agreement to be concluded at the earliest possible," Misri said.

The foreign secretary said trade was a key area of focus during Modi's separate bilateral meetings with UK Prime Minister Keir Starmer, Canadian PM Mark Carney, and European Union leaders Anto-

nio Costa and Ursula von der Leyen. Misri said the West Asia situation also figured prominently in PM Modi's engagements at G7 outreach meetings as well as in his bilateral talks.

PM Modi expressed India's desire to see sustained peace and security in West Asia, he added. US President Trump on Wednesday signed an initial agreement to end the war with Iran.

Misri said India has been in close touch with most of the protagonists who are involved or affected by the conflict.

"We remain in very close touch with all of those partners, and we'll be ready to do whatever it is, whatever it is possible for us to do, in so far as addressing the next steps," he said.

"India welcomed the developments that have taken place through the understanding that has been reached between the US and Iran and hopes to see a rapid return to peace and stability in the region," Misri said.

Historic spectacle: City gears up for Yoga Day grand slam

Continued from Page 1

Lead the nation in the Common Yoga Protocol. Describing it as one of the biggest Yoga Day gatherings ever, Union minister of state for AYUSH Prataprao Jadhav said the 2026 celebrations would unfold on an "unprecedented scale, with Kolkata hosting the flagship national event and serving as the epicentre of a nationwide wellness movement".

Ahead of the historic celebrations, Chief Minister Suvenud Adhikari and Union minister Prataprao Jadhav held a joint Press conference at Nabanna Sabhaghar on Thursday to showcase the scale of preparations for the mega event. The celebrations at Red Road are scheduled to begin at 5 am on June 21.

Addressing a preparatory programme, the two leaders emphasised this year's theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing", saying it reflects the growing importance of yoga in ensuring physical fitness, mental resilience and emotional well-

being in the face of changing lifestyles and an ageing population. They said the event would send a strong message on preventive healthcare while positioning Kolkata at the heart of a nationwide movement for holistic wellness.

"This is not merely a formal event but the beginning of a national celebration of India's knowledge tradition that has provided the world with a powerful path to balance, peace and holistic well-being," Jadhav said.

Chief Minister Adhikari and Jadhav, in the presence of Chief Postmaster General, West Bengal Circle, Shri Ashok Kumar, released twelve special philatelic covers commemorating International Day of Yoga 2026.

Addressing the media, Adhikari said that it is a matter of immense pride for West Bengal to host the national celebrations of the International Day of Yoga 2026 in Kolkata. He described Kolkata as a city known for its rich cultural, spiritual and intellectual

heritage, which continues to uphold the values of wellness and collective well-being.

Referring to this year's theme, "Yoga for Healthy Ageing", Adhikari emphasised that Yoga plays a crucial role in promoting physical vitality, mental resilience and emotional balance, enabling people to lead healthier and more fulfilling lives. He also appreciated the efforts of the Ministry of Ayush in taking Yoga to every corner of the country and transforming it into a year-round people's movement through various initiatives such as Yoga 365, Yoga for Healthy Ageing, Yoga for Non-Communicable Diseases, Yoga Park Initiative and 100 Days of Free Online Yoga, thereby strengthening India's global leadership in holistic health and wellness.

State Health minister Sharadwat Mukherjee, Manoj Agarwal, Chief Secretary, Vaidya Rajesh Kotecha, Secretary, Ministry of Ayush, were among the dignitaries present at the meeting.

A series of events is being

performed across the state in the run-up to June 21, including 'Cycling for Wellness', 'Yoga in Schools and Government Offices', 'Yoga for Mental Well-being', 'Women's Health Yoga', 'Yoga for Senior Citizens', 'Corporate Yoga' and Yoga programmes for police, fire services and healthcare institutions. A special initiative, "Daud Se Dhyani", will be organised on June 19 across eleven locations in Kolkata, followed by Vande Yogam and West Bengal Foundation Day celebrations on June 20 along the Hooghly riverfront featuring cultural performances, art competitions, photography contests and public engagement activities. The celebration will also feature mass Yoga demonstrations on 500 boats across the Hooghly River.

The Chief Minister and the Ayush Minister urged citizens, especially youth and senior citizens, to make Yoga a part of daily life and embrace it as a lifelong practice for physical health, mental peace and overall well-being.

From Page 1

Sena's missing

Deshmukh, Sanjay Jadhav, Sanjay Dina Patil, Omprakash Rajenimbalkar and Bhausaheb Wakchaure.

While Sawant said that show-cause notices would be issued to the six MPs, Raut claimed that their no-show would be considered a violation of the party whip.

Sources said all six dissident MPs have signed a letter seeking a merger with the Shinde-led Sena and submitted it to Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla.

The process, however, is not yet complete, as the speaker's office is understood to require the physical appearance of some of the MPs for verification and that is "expected to happen in the coming days", they said.

The verification of signatures is currently underway, the sources added.

Sawant said if the letter exists, the rebel MPs should make it public.

Shiv Sena (UBT) has nine MPs in the Lok Sabha and at least six will have to switch sides together to escape disqualification under the anti-defection law.

According to the sources, Shinde arrived in Delhi late on Tuesday and returned to Mumbai on Wednesday. He was the principal architect of the split in the undivided Shiv Sena in 2022 that brought down the Maha Vikas Aghadi government.

Meanwhile, the Maharashtra Police have accorded 'Y-Plus' security cover to six 'rebel' MPs of the Shiv Sena (UBT) amid threats issued by the party's leaders and workers over their alleged attempt to switch sides.

A letter signed by Shirish Jain, Commissioner of Intelligence, said security has been accorded to Sanjay Dina Patil (Mumbai-Northeast), Sanjay Deshmukh (Yavatmal-Washim), Sanjay Jadhav (Parbhani), Bhausaheb Wakchaure (Shirdi), Nagesh Patil-Ashitkar (Hingoli) and Omprakash Raje Nimbalkar (Osmanabad).

Accordingly, Y Plus security should be provided to these MPs with immediate effect. A Y-plus cover comprises 11 security personnel.

The direction to provide Y-plus security to the dissident MPs comes amid protests by party workers in their respective constituencies, threatening them with dire consequences if they switched sides.

PM takes India

"We had global discussions on development that we could eventually implement in India. We discussed shipbuilding, ship recycling, deep sea ports as well as building containers," Saade said after meeting Modi.

He further said: "I see great potential for France and India to continue cooperating and setting up new partnerships. As far as we are concerned, we view (the) relationship with our Indian partnerships very good and I believe that we can do more in the field of shipping and logistics."

"I believe that India has a major

role to play in the supply chains of the world. The fact that we are now in a position to build container ships in India is definitely a good step forward. The future of India is happening now," he added.

According to the MEA, Modi noted the groups' "strong and growing presence in India".

The MEA said in a post on X that Saade highlighted CMA CGM's plans for India, including "ongoing investments, expansion plans and initiatives that are leading to skill development, shipbuilding, expansion in logistics and innovation in supply chain".

Modi also met Benoit Bazin, Chairman and CEO of Saint-Gobain, and discussed opportunities in the materials and construction sector, with a particular emphasis on sustainability.

The prime minister noted Saint-Gobain's "strong presence and investments in India, which are creating opportunities for Indian youth", the MEA said.

Bazin shared Saint-Gobain's plans for "further investments and expansion in India", according to the ministry.

Modi separately met Martin Sion, CEO of Alstom, and discussed opportunities in mobility and railway modernisation.

The prime minister noted Alstom's "significant investments and manufacturing presence in India, which are contributing to job creation and the growth of India's rail sector", the MEA said.

Sion shared Alstom's plans for "further expansion and investments in India".

Modi also met Arthur Mensch, co-founder and CEO of Mistral AI, and highlighted opportunities in India's "growing AI ecosystem".

Mensch expressed Mistral AI's "strong interest in collaborating with India and partnering with Indian companies to drive innovation and expand AI capabilities", the MEA said.

In Paris, Modi is also scheduled to attend VivaTech 2026 - Europe's premier technology and innovation event - alongside French President Emmanuel Macron and interact with the Indian community.

NDA-backed Nathwani

The JMM used two additional votes to ensure the victory of its own candidate. The remaining four went to Congress.

In Jharkhand, the JMM has 34 MLAs, Congress 16, RJD 4, and CPI(M) 2 MLAs.

In a post on social media platform X, Nathawani -- a three-time member of the upper house -- expressed his gratitude.

The BJP-led NDA has 24 MLAs, four short of the minimum of 28 first-preference votes required in the 81-member assembly to secure a berth in the Upper House of Parliament.

The ruling INDIA bloc, including the JMM and the Congress, has 56 members in the House.

Soon after Nathwani's win, Congress launched a scathing attack on the saffron party, saying it promoted 'horse trading' in Jharkhand.

Congress minister Dipika Pandey Singh said, "The BJP fielded a corporate member as an Independent candidate and won the election by using money power. The BJP is promoting horse trading. However, we are happy that all Congress MLAs remained united and polled

in favour of the Congress candidate," she said.

Jharkhand Congress in-charge K Raju, who was also the polling agent for the election, also blamed alliance partners the RJD and CPI(M) Liberation for the defeat.

"RJD and CPI(M) Liberation betrayed us. They didn't vote for us, and that's why we lost. We received JMM's four votes, and all Congress legislators exercised their franchise in favour of our candidate," Raju told reporters.

Asked if the result would have an impact on the alliance, Raju said he would discuss the matter with Chief Minister Hemant Soren.

Jharkhand BJP chief Aditya Sahu congratulated Nathwani and said legislators exercised their franchise following their conscience.

"Despite our two votes being invalid, Nathwani managed 28 votes. It is a big win. Even members in the India bloc have shown faith in development works being carried out under the leadership of our Prime Minister Narendra Modi," Sahu said.

He rejected allegations of horse trading, asserting that the legislators cast their votes following their conscience.

Leader of Opposition Babul Marandi said the Jharkhand voters, especially BJP MLAs, were mature and sensible, and they know whom to vote for in the larger interest of the state.

"Nathwani has been an MP from Jharkhand for two terms from 2008 to 2020. People have seen his work. He again got the opportunity to serve Jharkhand, and people will get its benefit," Marandi, a former CM, said.

Another ex-chief minister and BJP leader Champai Soren expressed confidence that Nathwani would play a positive role in reaching the welfare schemes of the Centre to the people of Jharkhand.

Both the ruling and opposition camps had left no stone unturned to keep their MLAs intact ahead of the polling.

The NDA MLAs were shifted to a hotel in Ranchi on Tuesday, while the ruling INDIA bloc held meetings with its MLAs to thwart chances of cross-voting.

Meanwhile, on Mizoram, ruling Zoram People's Movement (ZPM) secured its first-ever representation in the Rajya Sabha as party candidate K Lalhuangkima won the election to the lone seat from the state.

Telegram curbs?

Justice Karia reserved the verdict after hearing extensive arguments from senior advocate Dhruv Mehta, appearing for the app, and Attorney General R Venkataramani and Solicitor General Tushar Mehta who represented the Centre.

The solicitor general referred to the technical aspects of the messaging app and said that a single Telegram account can create up to 40 bots.

"I will just give an example. In Telegram, one account user can create 40 bots. While in case of WhatsApp, it's one bot per user. They have multiplicity encouraging architecture and then the bots can further multiply," he said.

"Bots are machines; they can further multiply. As per the report, Telegram can offer bot infrastructure which can disseminate information in bulk. This feature is unique as it permits creation of sophisticated networks with minimal human oversight," the law officer said.

Justifying the decision, he said the government does not have this problem with other intermediaries.

"This platform operates through the cloud. Even if they block it and someone does mischief, law enforcement agencies cannot reach the actual user," he said.

Mehta also mentioned that the report indicated that Telegram is frequently used for terrorist activities and that law enforcement agencies face challenges due to this architectural design in various jurisdictions.

"The scale at which it can multiply is only available on Telegram. Also, suppose if they remove one bot, other bots can be created under different names and identifiers and therefore, measures against bots only have a temporary relief.

"We do not have this problem with other intermediaries like Facebook or WhatsApp. This platform operates through the cloud, even if we block something and someone does mischief, the law enforcement agency can't reach the person," he said.

"How can we stop the rights of 150 million people just because one set of citizens are appearing in examinations," the bench asked.

The law officer said there are a large number of groups and channels operating on this platform and such kinds of facilities are unheard of on other platforms.

"The question is can you block somebody else's rights to protect someone else's rights. The law has been laid down in the Anuradha Bhasin case (judgement)," the bench asked.

The law officer said that the apex court judgement in the Anuradha Bhasin case does not prohibit blocking.

While reserving the verdict, the judge asked the counsel for both parties to file their written submissions, if any, by 7 pm during the day.

When the law officer spoke about the paper leak and the app's probable role in it, Justice Karia further said, "We are all alive to the situation (of paper leak). There are so many students who were affected. But the aspect on the curb...can you ban the whole app? Let us focus on that. There is a power. That power can be exercised. To what extent can it be exercised?"

"The question here is, can you block someone else's right to protect somebody else," the bench asked.

The bench also asked if once the paper is leaked, and becomes viral, how can you deal with it on a real-time basis and once a complaint is received, and by the time action is taken, damage is done.

"What real-time surveillance is there on your platform," the bench asked.

The potential harm was huge and the app had been restricted under the powers to pass such a direction, and so the court could not interfere at the present stage, the solicitor general said.

"The goal is that the exam be conducted on June 21. And the goal is legitimate. I have shown that we have employed less restrictive measures," the law officer said.

The attorney general said that

the restrictive order "is complete and applies its mind".

He said that the app was someone who could not discharge its duty, and so it could not seek proportionality. "This platform, because of its unique architecture, I would say, is a Frankenstein."

On Wednesday, the high court asked the Centre to file its reply on Telegram's plea. The Ministry of Electronics and Information Technology (MeitY), acting on recommendations of the NTA, issued a direction under Section 69A of the Information Technology Act, 2000, restricting access to the Telegram platform in India till June 22, covering the day of the NEET (UG) 2026 re-examination and its immediate aftermath.

Doc kills househelp

Gupta's residence for several years.

Police said Gupta, an MBBS-qualified dermatologist in his 50s, was present near the body when officers arrived. He was immediately taken into custody and questioned. During preliminary interrogation, Gupta allegedly confessed to the attack. According to investigators, he told police that he first assaulted Meena with a bat and later stabbed her with a knife, causing fatal injuries. The woman died at the scene.

Police teams are now working to recover the weapons allegedly used in the crime. A forensic team has examined the spot and collected evidence as part of the ongoing investigation. A case has been registered under relevant sections of law.

According to police sources, Gupta claimed that he believed the victim was practising black magic and that her actions had disrupted the peace and well-being of his family. He allegedly told investigators that family members had been under considerable distress because of these suspicions.

However, officials said the accused has provided varying accounts during questioning, making it difficult to establish a clear motive at this stage. Investigators are therefore treating his claims with caution and are examining all possible angles.

Police also revealed that Gupta had reportedly been suffering from depression for some time. His mental health history is being examined to determine whether it may have played a role in the incident.

Investigators are probing the nature of the relationship between the accused and the victim and are looking into whether there were any recent disagreements or personal disputes that could have led to the killing. Statements of family members, neighbours and other potential witnesses are being recorded.

The shocking incident has left residents of the neighbourhood stunned, with many expressing disbelief over the alleged involvement of a medical professional in such a brutal crime. Police said the investigation remains at an early stage and further forensic findings and interrogation are expected to shed light on the exact circumstances surrounding the murder.

US lifts Iran

"So we're also honouring our end of the early part of the agreement on the military side," Vance said, citing it as an immediate benefit of the deal as he downplayed criticism that the agreement tilts in favour of Iran.

And in an extraordinary rebuke, he warned US critics in Israel against "attacking the only powerful ally" he has left.

He lashed out at members of the Israeli government, warning them that "Donald J. Trump is the only head of state in the entire world who is sympathetic to the nation of Israel at this moment in time."

Vance said he plans to travel to Switzerland for talks on the Iran deal but he doesn't know when that will happen. He had been expected to lead talks on implementing the agreement with Iran aimed at diluting its stockpile of highly enriched uranium and restarting oil traffic through the Strait of Hormuz.

On Tuesday, two oil tankers left Iran and crossed the US military blockade without being stopped. A merchant shipping tracking website said the ships were carrying a combined total of 3.8 million barrels of Iranian crude oil.

Meanwhile, Iranian state media said that shipping has "normalised" at Iran's southern ports but added that the Strait of Hormuz remains supervised and under the control of the Iranian military and transiting through the vital waterway still requires coordination.

India's Swiss

These are official figures reported by banks to the Swiss National Bank (SNB) and do not indicate the quantum of the much-debated alleged black money held by Indians in Switzerland. These figures also do not include the money that Indians, NRIs or others might have in Swiss banks in the names of third-country entities.

The total amount of CHF 3,250.5 million, described by the SNB as 'total liabilities' of Swiss banks or 'amounts due to' their Indian clients at the end of 2025, included CHF 524 million in customer deposits, CHF 2.6 billion held via other banks, CHF 18.6 million (down 55 per cent from CHF 41 million) through fiduciaries or trusts, and CHF 105.7 million as 'other amounts' due to customers in form of bonds, securities and various other financial instruments (down from CHF 135 million).

The total amount stood at a record high of nearly 6.5 billion Swiss francs in 2006, after which it has been mostly on a downward path, except for a few years, including in 2011, 2013, 2017, 2020, 2021, 2022, 2023 and 2024, as per SNB data.

According to the SNB, its data for 'total liabilities' of Swiss banks towards Indian clients takes into account all types of funds of Indian customers at Swiss banks, including deposits from individuals, banks and enterprises. This includes data for branches of Swiss banks in India, as well as non-deposit liabilities.

On the other hand, the 'local-national banking statistics' of the

Bank for International Settlements (BIS), which have been described in the past by Indian and Swiss authorities as a more reliable measure for deposits by Indian individuals in Swiss banks, showed an increase of 20 per cent during 2025 in such funds to USD 89.73 million (nearly Rs 780 crore).

It had risen by nearly 6 per cent in 2024, after dropping by 25 per cent in 2023, by 18 per cent in 2022 and by over 8 per cent in 2021. It rose by nearly 39 per cent in 2020.

It peaked at over USD 2.3 billion (over Rs 9,000 crore) at the end of 2007.

Swiss authorities have always maintained that assets held by Indian residents in Switzerland cannot be considered as 'black money' and they actively support India in its fight against tax fraud and evasion.

An automatic exchange of information in tax matters between Switzerland and India has been in force since 2018. Under this framework, detailed financial information on all Indian residents having accounts with Swiss financial institutions since 2018 was provided for the first time to Indian tax authorities in September 2019, and this is being followed every year.

In addition to this, Switzerland has been actively sharing details about accounts of Indians suspected to have indulged in financial wrongdoings after the submission of prima facie evidence. Such an exchange of information has taken place in hundreds of cases so far.

The overall funds of foreign clients, including institutions, declined by nearly 8 per cent in 2025 to CHF 1.05 trillion.

In terms of assets, Indian clients accounted for CHF 1.5 billion at the end of 2024, down nearly 6 per cent from the previous year.

While the UK topped the charts for foreign clients' money in Swiss banks at CHF 192 billion, it was followed by the US (CHF 75 billion) at the second spot and France (CHF 63 billion) at the third place.

These three were followed in the top 10 by the West Indies, Germany, Hong Kong, Singapore, Luxembourg, UAE and the Netherlands. India was placed at 46th place, up from 48th place at the end of 2024.

Pakistan also saw a dip to CHF 257 million (from CHF 272 million), while Bangladesh witnessed a sharp increase of 43 per cent to CHF 842 million. Just like in India, the issue of alleged black money in Swiss banks has been a political hot potato in the two neighbouring countries as well.

Bangladesh was at 81st place, while Pakistan was at 108th.

Net income tax

Refunds worth Rs 89,026 crore was issued till May 17, registering an increase of 1.19 per cent over the year-ago period.

On a gross basis, direct tax collection increased 12.46 per cent to over Rs 6.10 lakh crore. This includes corporate tax of over Rs 2.76 lakh crore and NCT of about Rs 3.15 lakh crore.

The government has budgeted to collect Rs 26.97 lakh crore from direct taxes in the current fiscal year, a 15 per cent growth over Rs 23.40 lakh crore collected in FY26.

Rahul launches campaign for education reform

Urges students to join ‘chhatron ki goonj’ movement

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Congress leader Rahul Gandhi on Thursday launched a signature campaign to amplify issues related to the nation's education system, such as paper leaks and high fees, asserting that it is a platform for students to make demands directly to the government.

In a post on X, Gandhi posted a link to the campaign where students can share ideas and sign a petition.

"If you've suffered because of paper leaks, exam issues, or high fees, if this education system has shattered your dreams, if your family has invested a lifetime of savings in your education, then 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' is your voice," the Leader of Opposition in the Lok Sabha said in the post.

Gandhi noted that this initiative goes beyond just a campaign; it is a platform for students to raise issues such as the need for



Congress leader Rahul Gandhi speaks during the 'Chhatron Ki Goonj' rally, in Kota, Rajasthan PTI

Highlights

- » In a post on X, Gandhi posted a link to the campaign where students can share ideas and sign a petition
- » Gandhi noted that this initiative goes beyond just a campaign
- » Gandhi's appeal for participation in campaign followed a day after he interacted with students in Kota

affordable education, fair examinations, and dignified employment opportunities.

"Join the movement: Click the link below. Fill in your name and share your ideas. Sign the petition -- that's it," Gandhi said, urging the youth to sign up for this movement. "More the signatures, louder the goonj!" he added.

His appeal for participation in the campaign followed a

day after he interacted with students at a convention in Kota, Rajasthan.

During this interaction, he described India's education system as a "rejection system" rather than a selection system, claiming it places an excessive financial burden and causes significant stress to students and middle-class families.

While addressing the gathering in Kota, known for its coaching

centres, Gandhi remarked that the current education structure is "extremely stressful and unfair."

"This is not good for the country. I want all of us to work together to ensure that no student in this country ever feels what this girl felt," he said at the "Chhatron ki Goonj" Maha Rally in Kota, where he interacted with students on various issues like paper leaks and unemployment.

LDF, UDF TRADE CHARGES PM SHRI scheme row triggers new political storm in Kerala

OUR CORRESPONDENT

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM: The UDF government's move to implement the PM SHRI scheme, which the Congress-led alliance had opposed tooth and nail while in Opposition, has triggered a political storm in Kerala, with the Opposition LDF on Thursday accusing the ruling dispensation of presenting an "incorrect" narrative on the matter.

Amid growing criticism on social media, including from UDF supporters, over the government's move, state Health Minister K Muraleedharan asserted that the initiative, signed during the previous Left government, will be implemented.

Leader of Opposition in the state Assembly, Pinarayi Vijayan, rejected the UDF government's claim regarding the PM SHRI scheme, saying it was never implemented in the state and that no funds were received under it.

Vijayan, at a press conference here, also claimed that imple-



Students attend the IDEAL (Interactive Digital, Experimental, Administration and Learning) centre at PM SHRI Zilla Parishad School, in Raigad PTI

mentation of the scheme was "frozen" or "kept in abeyance" by the LDF government right after it was signed, and that a letter was issued to the Centre communicating the same.

The Marxist veteran's statement came a day after Chief Minister V D Satheesan claimed that his government was "forced to implement" the scheme as it had been signed by the previous LDF government, which also received funds in connection with it.

Reiterating the UDF government's stand, Muraleedharan said the Pradhan Mantri Schools for Rising India scheme will be implemented in Kerala, but the state will decide the curriculum.

"In many BJP-ruled states, references to the Mughal dynasty and its rule in India are being avoided. We will not do that. We will include it. History will be taught to children without any changes," he told reporters.

"The state government will select the schools where the scheme will be implemented. With these two conditions, PM SHRI will be implemented in Kerala. That is what the Cabinet decided," he added.

In his press conference, Vijayan said the new UDF government must disclose before the people what prompted it to change its policy and decide to implement the scheme.

Jharkhand RS poll defeat shows Rahul not acceptable to allies: BJP

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The BJP on Thursday said the Rajya Sabha seat result in Jharkhand shows that allies in the INDIA bloc have rejected Rahul Gandhi's leadership.

The ruling party at the Centre also called Gandhi a "liability" for the INDIA Bloc.

Amid cross-voting, NDA-supported Independent candidate Parimal Nathwani on Thursday won one of the two Rajya Sabha seats in Jharkhand, defeating the Congress's Pranav Jha.

Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) candidate Baidyanath Ram was elected to the other seat. Nathwani polled 28 votes, while Jha bagged 20 votes.

BJP spokesperson Shehzad Poonawalla alleged that the Opposition alliance is plagued by infighting.

‘Hopeful of police permission’: CJP gears up for June 20 protest

This would be second protest at Jantar Mantar

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The youth-led Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) on Thursday said it would go ahead with its proposed protest at Jantar Mantar on June 20 seeking the resignation of Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan over the NEET paper leak controversy, and expressed hope that Delhi Police would grant permission for the demonstration.

The June 20 mobilisation is expected to culminate in an indefinite sit-in demanding Pradhan's resignation, according to the organisation.

Addressing a press conference here, CJP spokesperson Saurav Das said the organisation had called for a peaceful protest and had approached Delhi Police for permission.

"We have given a call for a peaceful protest. We have requested the Delhi Police's cooperation and are hopeful that permission will be granted. This will be a peaceful protest at Jantar Mantar," Das said, and invited artists and singers to join and perform at the demonstration.

CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka alleged that four NEET aspirants had died by suicide in the last 24 hours and claimed that 11 students had died by suicide since the NEET paper



Abhijeet Dipke

leak issue came to light.

"Four families have been destroyed. Since the NEET paper leak, 11 students have died by suicide," Ranka said, demanding Rs 1 crore compensation for the families of the deceased students.

He reiterated the organisation's firm demand for Pradhan's resignation. "Our position is clear. We want Dharmendra Pradhan to resign. We are coming again on June 20 for a protest because there has been no communication from the government," Ranka said.

He extended his wishes to students about to take the examination, expressing hope that by the time the exam process concludes, the education minister would have been replaced.

Ranka stated that Pradhan's continued leadership, despite the ongoing controversy, raises serious questions about democratic accountability.

Some actor copying me, says CM Mann over objectionable video row

‘Man in the alleged objectionable footage was someone else’

OUR CORRESPONDENT

CHANDIGARH: Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Thursday reiterated that it was not him in an objectionable video over which a Sikh clergy issued an edict against him, saying some actor was imitating him with an intent to defame him.

Mann also cited reports of two labs, showing that the man in the alleged objectionable footage was someone else.

He further said he was being targeted by those who could not tolerate pro-people decisions being taken by him.

The Akal Takht on Monday declared Mann 'Guru Dokhi' (anti-Guru) and 'Khalsa Panth virodhi' (anti-Khalsa Panth) over the video.

In a video statement, Mann said he was not in the video, claiming that some actor was imitating him in it and with hair like him.

Citing findings of reports of the two labs in connection with the objectionable video, he said a total of 1,191 frames in that video were checked.

"Not even a single frame (in



Punjab Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann speaks in a video message, in Chandigarh PTI

the video) matched the front or side portion of my face or my physique. It becomes clear that this video was made with an intention of defaming me," said Mann.

He further said there is a difference of one inch in his height as compared to the individual seen in the video. "How could it be possible that my height increases by one inch in the video?" he asked while sharing the outcome of the lab reports.

"When and where this video was made, it is not known," he further said.

Targeting his rivals, he said the pro-people decisions being taken by him were not being tolerated as he pointed towards works being undertaken by his government.



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ROZGAR YA KAROBAAR

SAATH HAI BHARAT SARKAR



Pradhan Mantri Viksit Bharat Rozgar Yojana

Hon'ble Prime Minister
Shri Narendra Modi

to

Disburse Incentive of
₹2,400 Crore

Employment to 15 Lakh Beneficiaries

Incentive of up to
₹15,000 for First Time Employees


Supporting Employment
Generation

Incentive of up to ₹3,000 for
Employers on each additional hiring


Enhancing
Employability


Incentivizing Formal
Employment


Expansion of
Social Security

In the august presence of

Dr. Mansukh Mandaviya
Hon'ble Union Minister for Labour & Employment
and Youth Affairs & Sports, Government of India

Sushri Shobha Karandlaje
Hon'ble Minister of State for Labour & Employment
and Micro, Small & Medium Enterprises, Government of India

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EDITORIAL

FRAGILE PEACE?

The interim agreement between the United States and Iran, reached after more than three months of devastating conflict, appears to be one such moment. The deal has halted a war that destabilised the Middle East, sent oil prices soaring, disrupted global supply chains and heightened fears of a wider regional confrontation. Yet beneath the relief lies a difficult question: what, exactly, has changed?

At first glance, the agreement offers tangible gains. The reopening of the Strait of Hormuz restores one of the world's most critical energy arteries. Nearly a fifth of globally traded oil passes through this narrow waterway, making it indispensable to energy security. Its closure had driven fuel prices higher, fuelled inflation and created uncertainty across economies already struggling with geopolitical shocks. Reopening the route should bring immediate relief to consumers and markets alike. Iran also secures a significant economic reprieve. Sanctions on its oil exports have been waived, allowing Tehran to return to international markets and regain access to a revenue stream worth tens of billions of dollars annually. For an economy battered by war and isolation, this is no small concession.

Yet the larger strategic picture is more ambiguous. After thousands of deaths, extensive destruction and months of instability, the United States and Iran appear to have arrived close to where they stood before hostilities erupted. The core dispute over Iran's nuclear programme remains unresolved. The agreement merely creates a 60-day negotiating window during which both sides will attempt to craft a broader settlement. The war may have paused, but the fundamental disagreements that produced it remain intact.

This reality raises uncomfortable questions about the effectiveness of military coercion as a tool of diplomacy. The United States and Israel entered the conflict with ambitious objectives. They sought to cripple Iran's military capabilities, weaken its regional influence and ensure that it could never develop a nuclear weapon. While Iranian military infrastructure undoubtedly suffered significant damage, Tehran has emerged politically intact. Its governing system survived. Its oil exports are resuming. Its regional alliances remain largely functional. Far from achieving a decisive transformation, the war seems to have reinforced a long-standing lesson of international relations: military victories do not automatically translate into political solutions.

The coming negotiations will therefore be crucial. The benchmark remains the 2015 nuclear agreement, which imposed strict limits on Iran's enrichment activities and subjected its facilities to extensive international monitoring. Critics argued that the deal was temporary and failed to address Iran's missile programme or regional activities. President Donald Trump withdrew from that accord, insisting a stronger agreement could be negotiated. The challenge now is whether Washington can deliver a framework that is both more durable and more comprehensive than the one it abandoned.

There are reasons for scepticism. Notably absent from the interim agreement are meaningful provisions concerning Iran's missile arsenal and its support for regional proxy groups. These issues have long been central to American and Israeli security concerns. Their exclusion suggests that the negotiations ahead may focus narrowly on nuclear restrictions while leaving other sources of regional instability untouched. Such an approach could reduce immediate tensions without resolving the broader strategic competition that has defined Middle Eastern politics for decades.

Another source of uncertainty lies in Lebanon. The agreement envisions an end to hostilities involving Hezbollah and Israel, yet the arrangement formally binds neither party. Israeli forces remain in parts of southern Lebanon, while Hezbollah continues to present itself as a resistance movement committed to opposing Israeli occupation. Any escalation along this front could quickly undermine the fragile diplomatic progress achieved between Washington and Tehran.

The deal also exposes growing strains within the American-Israeli partnership. Israeli leaders have expressed deep dissatisfaction with the agreement, viewing it as a concession that allows Iran to recover economically without making irreversible strategic sacrifices. Divergences between Washington and Jerusalem are not new, but they have become increasingly visible. Managing these tensions may prove almost as challenging as negotiating with Tehran itself.

For the wider world, however, the immediate priority is stability. Energy markets need predictability. Global trade requires secure shipping routes. Regional populations deserve respite from violence. In that sense, the interim accord serves an important purpose. It creates breathing space where none existed before.

But peace agreements should ultimately be judged not by the wars they pause but by the futures they create. The next sixty days will determine whether this accord becomes the foundation for a lasting settlement or merely an intermission before another cycle of confrontation. The world has seen too many temporary truces mistaken for permanent solutions. What happens next will reveal whether diplomacy can succeed where war has failed.

ILLNESS TO WELLNESS



ANIL RAJPUT

THE WRITER IS THE CHAIRPERSON, ADVISORY COUNCIL, ILLNESS TO WELLNESS FOUNDATION

India's battle against sickle cell disease requires more than awareness campaigns—it demands timely diagnosis, community support and equitable healthcare access

Building an Equitable Future

World Sickle Cell Day 2026 highlights the urgent need to ensure equitable access to screening, diagnosis, treatment and lifelong care for every patient

Every year, World Sickle Cell Day reminds us that some health challenges remain painful not only because of biology, but because of silence, delay and unequal access to care. Sickle cell disease is an inherited blood disorder, but the suffering it causes is often shaped by social realities. A child who is diagnosed early, receives regular follow-up, has access to medicines, safe blood transfusion when needed, vaccinations, counselling and family support can live a far better life than one whose pain is misunderstood, ignored or treated too late. This is why World Sickle Cell Day is not merely an occasion for awareness. It is a call for equity, dignity and timely action.

The theme for World Sickle Cell Day 2026, "Closing the Survival Gap: Equity in Sickle Cell Disease," is especially relevant for India. The phrase "survival gap" asks an important question: why should a person's chance of living well with sickle cell disease depend on where they are born, whether they live in a remote village or a city, whether their family can reach a hospital, or whether their community understands the condition? In simple terms, equity means that every person affected by sickle cell disease should have access to screening, diagnosis, treatment, counselling and long-term care, regardless of geography, income or background.

Sickle cell disease affects the red blood cells, which carry oxygen through the body. In people with this condition, some red blood cells become hard, sticky and sickle-shaped. These cells can block blood flow, causing episodes of severe pain, fatigue, infections, anaemia and complications affecting different organs. It is not contagious. It is passed from parents to children through genes. This distinction is important because stigma and misinformation can often worsen the burden on families. People living with sickle cell disease do not need blame or isolation.



People living with sickle cell disease do not need blame or isolation. They need understanding, support and dignity

tion. They need understanding, medical support and social acceptance.

For India, sickle cell disease has particular public-health importance because it affects many tribal and underserved communities. The National Sickle Cell Anaemia Elimination Mission has therefore become one of the country's most significant health initiatives in this field. Its focus on screening, counselling, prevention and care marks a shift from waiting for illness to become severe to identifying risk early and supporting families before complications multiply. The mission's aim to screen crores of people, especially in high-prevalence tribal regions, reflects the scale of the challenge and the seriousness of India's response.

What makes the present moment different is the way India is combining public health with technology and last-mile delivery. Screening is being taken closer to communities through health facilities ranging from district hospitals to Ayushman Arogya Mandirs. Digital tools are helping health workers register individuals, link records with ABHA (Ayushman Bharat Health

Accounts) IDs and record screening and confirmatory test details. Point-of-care testing and confirmatory diagnostic methods are making it easier to identify affected individuals and carriers. Genetic counselling and awareness activities are also helping families understand the condition, inheritance patterns and available care options.

These innovations matter because sickle cell care cannot depend only on specialist hospitals. A person living with sickle cell disease requires lifelong support. This includes regular follow-up, pain management, infection prevention, nutrition advice, mental health support, timely referral and access to medicines. For families, counselling is equally important. When people understand the difference between being a carrier and having the disease, they are better able to make informed decisions without fear or stigma. Awareness must therefore be sensitive. It must never turn genetic information into discrimination. It must empower, not label.

India can also learn from international experience. In several countries, newborn

screening has shown the value of diagnosing sickle cell disease early in life, so that preventive care can begin before severe complications occur. Global health guidance also reminds us that proven interventions already exist. Vaccination, infection prevention, hydroxyurea, pain care, transfusion support and regular monitoring can significantly improve outcomes when they are accessible and consistently delivered. The lesson is clear: survival improves when care is organised, continuous and close to the patient.

At the same time, the world is witnessing remarkable scientific progress. Gene therapies approved in some countries have opened a new chapter in sickle cell treatment. These developments are important and inspiring. However, they also raise an ethical question. If advanced therapies remain available only to a small number of people in wealthy settings, the survival gap may widen instead of closing. Scientific innovation must therefore move together with public-health equity. The future of sickle cell care should not be divided between those who can access cutting-edge treatment

and those who still struggle for basic diagnosis.

For India, the priority must be a balanced approach. We must welcome medical innovation, but we must also strengthen the basics: awareness, early screening, counselling, regular medicines, blood safety, trained health workers, referral pathways and community trust. Schools, panchayats, youth groups, self-help groups, workplaces, health centres and civil society organisations can all play a role in spreading accurate information. Community leaders can help reduce stigma. Families can encourage testing. Young people can become ambassadors for informed health choices. Health systems can ensure that no patient is dismissed when they report pain, because pain in sickle cell disease is real and often severe.

Illness to Wellness Foundation believes that true wellness is not limited to the absence of disease. It includes knowledge, prevention, dignity, early action and compassionate support. On World Sickle Cell Day 2026, we must recognise that awareness is the first step, but not the final goal. Awareness must lead to screening. Screening must lead to counselling. Counselling must lead to care. Care must lead to a life where every child, adolescent and adult living with sickle cell disease is treated not as a statistic, but as a person with dreams, potential and rights.

Closing the survival gap is therefore not only a medical responsibility. It is a social responsibility. A healthier India will be built when no family has to suffer silently because of lack of information, lack of access or lack of support. Let this World Sickle Cell Day become a reminder that inherited conditions require collective compassion, scientific commitment and public-health action. When we bring diagnosis closer, treatment earlier and dignity into every conversation, we move from illness to wellness in the truest sense.

Views expressed are personal

SHARED WILDERNESS



DIBYENDU MANDAL

THE WRITER IS A WILDLIFE BIOLOGIST WHO LEADS THE FOREST AND WILDLIFE PROGRAMME AT THE SANKALA FOUNDATION, NEW DELHI

The seven big cats—Tiger, Leopard, Lion, Snow leopard, Cheetah, Jaguar, and Puma—occur across nearly 74 per cent of the Earth's landmass, albeit in fragmented patches

Saving Big Cats Across Borders

From Sundarbans tigers to Amazon jaguars, protecting the world's largest predators requires nations to work beyond borders

The tigers of the Sundarbans mangroves, snow leopards of the Altai Mountains (Central Asia), Persian leopards of the Alborz–Kopetdag Mountains, lions of the Kavango–Zambezi landscape (Southern Africa), and jaguars of the north-western Amazon (South America) all share one thing in common: viable big cat populations divided by international borders. Although borders may not directly hinder wildlife movement, they can alter the condition of habitats through differential implementation of policies, enforcement, and management, as well as unequal socio-economic and political conditions among nations. This often results in unequal impacts on the big cat populations that these countries sustain.

The Siberian tiger population in China and Russia over recent decades provides a notable example. While the habitat remained largely contiguous on either side of the border, hunting and large-scale habitat loss led to a severe decline in China, where the population fell to fewer than 20 individuals in the 1990s. Across the border in Russia, habitat protection programs were largely successful in preserving the habitat, but hunting caused the tiger population to decline to around 150 individuals in the 1990s.

However, protection and conservation efforts helped the population recover from around 150 individuals in the 1990s to over 500 now. These long-term conservation efforts on the Russian side risked failure unless similar efforts were enforced across the border in China. Long-term transboundary conservation efforts in China have since led to a modest recovery to around 50 individuals. International cooperation has therefore been imperative for the long-term conservation of big cats globally.

The seven big cats—Tiger, Leopard, Lion, Snow leopard, Cheetah, Jaguar, and Puma—occur across nearly 74 per cent of the Earth's landmass, albeit



The future of the world's seven big cats depends on coordinated conservation, shared enforcement and sustained international commitment

in fragmented patches. The ecosystem services provided by big cats are now well recognised in public discourse. By maintaining habitat health, they help secure crucial ecosystem services such as water security, food security, and ecological stability. Conserving them is therefore not merely an option, but a necessity for human well-being.

Although, most big cats fall under the International Union for Conservation of Nature (IUCN) red list status of 'vulnerable' or 'near threatened', many of their sub-species fall under the 'endangered' or 'critically endangered' category (facing an high or extremely high risk of extinction) such as the Asiatic Lion, Persian Leopard, Malayan Tiger, Arabian Leopard, and Asiatic Cheetah due to habitat loss, isolation, and continued persecution. These big cat populations remain fragmented, and contiguous landscapes supporting viable populations often extend across international boundaries.

Long-term conservation success,

therefore, depends on transboundary cooperation. Such collaborations frequently create enabling conditions for knowledge exchange and technical support among nations with unequal capacities and resources. Most importantly, transboundary efforts have the potential to bridge the gap between policy, differential law enforcement and protection. Several transboundary initiatives have demonstrated positive outcomes in the past. Beyond multilateral conventions and treaties, initiatives such as the Global Snow Leopard and Ecosystem Protection Programme across snow leopard range countries, the Kavango–Zambezi Transfrontier Conservation Area for African lions, cheetahs, and leopards, and the Jaguar Corridor Initiative are important examples. These initiatives were also a result of transboundary consultation, shared visions, and, most importantly, a targeted approach.

The proposed International Big Cat Alliance (IBCA) Summit in Delhi

later this year presents another opportunity to identify big cat landscapes with unequal population trends, facilitate knowledge transfer, mainstream transboundary cooperation, build support for big cat conservation, and promote recovery efforts. It could help revive global momentum and stimulate discussions on safeguarding the last strongholds of the world's big cats. This forum would also provide an ideal platform to establish measurable targets for conserving the seven big cats and their habitats. Without clear goals, long-term commitments, or a roadmap for future cooperation, this opportunity risks being missed.

More such engagements are expected to drive a high level of political commitment. So will the engagement of policymakers and corporate executives who can help bridge the gap between environment and development goals. It will be a valuable opportunity to collectively garner support and build momentum for global big cat conservation. The path ahead remains challenging, and lessons from past experiences must be carefully considered.

Among intergovernmental conservation meetings, the 2010 tiger summit held in St. Petersburg may be considered monumental. The summit concluded with the St. Petersburg Declaration, which established the ambitious TX2 goal of doubling global tiger numbers along with a clear framework for future action. More than a decade later, the summit remains a major success in tiger conservation and effectively delivered its intended outcomes. India was one of the few countries that were able to meet the goals earlier, along with Nepal, Bhutan, and Russia. India today has 70 per cent of the global tiger population.

Let us hope that the world comes together more often on such platforms for more remarkable achievements for big cat conservation.

Views expressed are personal

GLOBAL LESSONS



C RAJ KUMAR
THE WRITER IS THE FOUNDING VICE CHANCELLOR OF O.P. JINDAL GLOBAL UNIVERSITY

Japan provides one of the most outstanding examples of inclusive economic growth, with equality and dignity at the core of its economic and social development

The Inclusion Imperative

Japan's post-war success shows that enduring prosperity emerges when economic growth expands opportunities and strengthens the middle class

Indian PM Narendra Modi and Japanese PM Sanae Takaichi will hold a summit-level meeting in Guwahati, Assam, during which a number of aspects of the India-Japan relationship will be discussed. The focus of this meeting will include collaboration in the fields of infrastructure, supply chains, semiconductors, AI, and technology. The discussions between the two Prime Ministers will further expand and deepen the relationship. I believe there is something even more valuable that India can draw from Japan. This concerns India's vision of establishing an egalitarian society through the expansion of its middle class. The question of inclusive economic growth will be one of the most important social, economic, political, and moral challenges of our time.

Beyond Economic Growth: The Real Meaning of Viksit Bharat

The Viksit Bharat vision and our aspiration to become a developed country by 2047 are not just about becoming wealthier. At its heart lies the goal of enabling a more cohesive society, where the benefits of development are democratised and have a wider impact. India will soon become the world's third-largest economy and will have the potential to achieve even greater heights. Notwithstanding this imminent progress, the most critical question policymakers must ask is not how to create wealth. It is whether India can build a society in which millions of people are able to participate in that wealth creation and how it will transform their lives.

Japan provides one of the most outstanding examples of inclusive economic growth, with equality and dignity at the core of its economic and social development.

Japan's Greatest Success: Building a Middle-Class Society

When the story of Japan's post-Second World War miracle is told, it often highlights industrial growth, technological advancement, manufacturing excellence, and innovation. Yet Japan's greatest achievement was the creation of an egalitarian society. It consciously worked towards becoming an inclusive "hundred-million middle-class society," recognising that economic development alone would not ensure national stability. Japan harnessed the market economy to foster innovation, entrepreneurship, exports, and technological leadership while ensuring that the benefits of growth reached ordinary citizens. Driven by globally successful companies and sustained growth, Japan also nurtured a belief that hard work, education, resilience, and talent could improve lives, strengthening social trust and national cohesion.



Japan's greatest achievement was building an inclusive, egalitarian middle-class society, recognising that economic growth alone could not guarantee national stability

India is uniquely positioned today. It has not only become the world's fastest-growing major economy but is also home to one of the largest and most dynamic startup ecosystems in the world. India's commitment to democratising technology and developing digital public infrastructure has contributed to financial inclusion, improved public service delivery, and enhanced transparency in governance on an unprecedented scale.

India's Defining Development Challenge

The real question is whether growth in India can be inclusive and whether wealth creation can contribute to the emergence of a large and confident middle class. Our aspiration to build a developed nation by 2047 will necessarily and inextricably be linked to this public policy objective. The question is not how many billionaires India produces, but how many citizens are able to achieve economic security, attain upward social mobility, and access opportunities.

What Can India Learn from Japan?

► The Private Sector Must Become the Engine of Middle-Class Expansion

Middle-class societies are built through wealth creation, not wealth destruction. Japan never viewed successful businesses as a problem; it regarded business and industry as national assets that drive growth and development. Large corporations, together with thousands of small and medium enterprises, created millions of jobs, powered innovation, expanded exports, and strengthened middle-class prosperity. This offers an important lesson for India. Building the world's largest middle class will require globally competitive companies, manufacturing and services growth, innovation hubs, startups, entrepreneurship, and strong private-sector participation. The next phase of India-Japan cooperation should focus on creating high-quality jobs across manufacturing, technology, semiconductors, green industries, and AI-driven sectors.

► Human Capital Is the Foundation of Prosperity

Education and healthcare in Japan were not viewed as welfare programmes

but as essential components of economic infrastructure. Japan has achieved literacy rates exceeding 99 per cent. Japanese students consistently rank among the world's best in mathematics, science, and reading. Japan's commitment to public health has resulted in universal healthcare coverage and a life expectancy exceeding 85 years.

The next frontier of public policy in India is to emphasise quality within growth. Our aspiration should not merely be to provide access to schools but to ensure excellence in learning; not simply access to healthcare but measurable improvements in health outcomes. There is a strong case for India and Japan to expand cooperation in vocational education and training, healthcare systems, human resource development, addressing the challenges of ageing populations, and promoting lifelong learning.

► Inclusive Growth Requires Regional Development

Japan deliberately spread economic development across the country through industrial clusters, transportation networks, universities, and regional infrastructure. India has long faced this

challenge. India's middle class and its future cannot depend entirely on Delhi, Mumbai, Hyderabad, Bengaluru, and Chennai. The growth of India and its benefits should increasingly originate from Tier-2 and Tier-3 cities. Manufacturing clusters, logistics networks, industrial ecosystems, higher education institutions, and investments in infrastructure, science and technology, artificial intelligence, and other technology-driven industries must be distributed more widely across the country.

► Social Mobility Is More Important Than Wealth Redistribution

The story of Japan's economic development was not about equality of outcomes; it was about equality of opportunity. India's development challenge, therefore, is to expand pathways for social mobility. Access to finance, quality education, healthcare, digital infrastructure, entrepreneurship, housing, and justice should become more universal. Japan has shown the world that social mobility can become one of the most important foundations of national development and community cohesion.

► Social Cohesion Ought to Be the Purpose of Growth

Economic development cannot be viewed as an end in itself. The aspiration of Indian society should be to create a nation where ordinary citizens are able to participate in the vision of development and prosperity. This will strengthen public trust. Wealth generation can occur without inclusion; however, growth accompanied by inclusion creates social stability and community cohesion.

A New Era of India-Japan Cooperation

Over the past few decades, India and Japan have built a partnership centred on infrastructure, manufacturing, technology, and strategic geopolitical engagement. The next era of cooperation should focus on the evolution of a broad-based middle-class society. Japan's experience in skills development, education, healthcare, social stability, and regional development offers valuable lessons for India, while India's strengths in digital public infrastructure, entrepreneurship, and demographic dynamism complement Japan's experience.

As India moves towards Viksit Bharat 2047, its defining mission should be to build not just the world's largest economy, but its largest and most inclusive middle-class society. Japan's greatest lesson is that prosperity matters most when it is widely shared, creating opportunity, stability, and social cohesion.

Views expressed are personal

LEGACY PRESERVED



SIDDHARTH SINGH
THE WRITER IS THE VICE-CHANCELLOR OF NAVA NALANDA MAHAVIHARA (DEEMED UNIVERSITY), NALANDA, UNDER THE MINISTRY OF CULTURE

The digitisation of ancient manuscripts is turning cultural preservation into a national movement of knowledge recovery

From Palm to Pixel

Through Gyan Bharatam, India is undertaking one of the world's most ambitious efforts to preserve, digitise and democratise its vast manuscript heritage

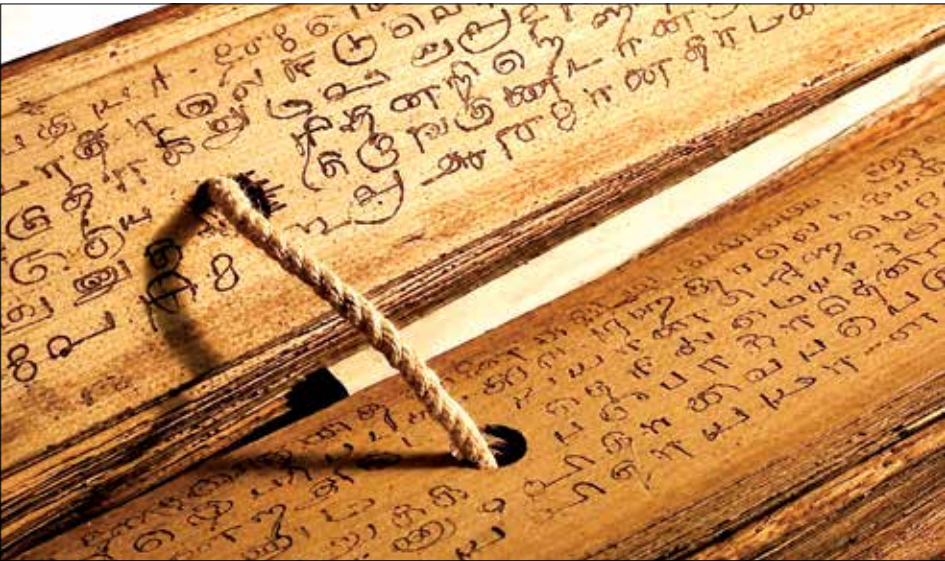
Imagine a centuries-old manuscript lying quietly in a temple library, a monastery archive, or a family chest. Written on fragile palm leaves or birch bark, it may contain insights on medicine, astronomy, mathematics, philosophy, agriculture, or governance-knowledge that has survived generations but now risks being lost to time.

For India, preserving such manuscripts is not merely about saving old documents. It is about safeguarding the memory of a civilisation.

India possesses one of the world's richest manuscript traditions. Across the country, millions of manuscripts are preserved in temples, monasteries, libraries, research institutions, and private collections. Written in diverse scripts such as Devanagari, Sharada, Grantha, Tamil, Telugu, Kannada, Malayalam, Modi, Kaithi, and Perso-Arabic, these texts reflect centuries of intellectual inquiry across multiple languages and disciplines.

Yet much of this treasure remained scattered, undocumented, and inaccessible for decades. Many manuscripts faced the constant threat of decay from humidity, insects, environmental damage, and simple neglect. Scholars often knew that valuable collections existed but had little information about where they were located or what they contained.

That is now beginning to change. In 2025, the Ministry of Culture launched Gyan Bharatam, an ambitious initiative aimed at preserving, documenting, digitising, and making accessible



Every manuscript preserved is a story recovered, a tradition remembered, and a piece of civilisational memory passed on to the future

India's vast manuscript heritage. More than a conservation project, the initiative seeks to reconnect modern India with its knowledge traditions and make them available to future generations.

The scale of the mission is extraordinary. Its long-term objective is to survey and document over ten million manuscripts across the country. Through digitisation, these fragile records can be preserved permanently while becoming accessible to students, researchers, and citizens without risking damage to the original documents.

The initiative gained international attention during the 2025 conference, "Reclaiming India's Knowledge Legacy

through Manuscript Heritage", held at New Delhi's Vigyan Bhavan. Scholars, archivists, conservation experts, and technology specialists from India and abroad came together to discuss a simple but powerful idea: manuscripts are not merely historical artefacts; they are living repositories of knowledge.

This shift in thinking mirrors developments taking place around the world. Today, cultural preservation is increasingly focused not only on protecting heritage but also on making it accessible. Digital archives, artificial intelligence, and advanced imaging technologies are transforming how ancient texts are studied and understood.

Europe's digital heritage platform, Europeana, has dem-

onstrated the possibilities of large-scale digitisation by bringing together hundreds of thousands of manuscripts and historical records from museums, libraries, and archives. Artificial intelligence is now helping researchers decipher difficult handwriting, identify authors and historical contexts, and recover information from damaged texts. Multispectral imaging can even reveal words that have become invisible over centuries of wear and deterioration.

India's challenge and opportunity is even larger.

Unlike many manuscript traditions that are concentrated within a few languages, India's manuscript heritage spans dozens of languages, scripts, regions, and knowledge systems. This

diversity makes preservation more complex, but it also makes the country's intellectual legacy uniquely valuable.

Recognising this, the Ministry of Culture launched the Gyan Bharatam National Manuscript Survey in 2026. The survey seeks to create a nationwide map of manuscript collections through digital platforms and mobile applications. Families, institutions, temples, monasteries, and scholars can voluntarily register information about manuscripts in their possession, helping build a comprehensive national database.

Technology is playing a central role in this effort. Advanced techniques such as multispectral imaging, digital archiving, AI-assisted transcription, and machine-learning-based text reconstruction are being integrated into preservation work. Institutions such as the Asiatic Society in Kolkata, along with technical partners including IITs and C-DAC, are contributing expertise to develop innovative solutions for manuscript conservation and accessibility.

Equally important is the collaborative model adopted by the initiative. Government agencies are working alongside universities, trusts, traditional learning centres, community organisations, and private custodians of manuscripts. This public-private partnership approach recognises a simple reality: a heritage of this scale cannot be preserved by any single institution alone.

The impact of this collective effort is already visible. Thousands of manuscripts have

been identified, catalogued, and digitised, while rare collections previously known only to local communities are gradually entering the national knowledge network. According to official figures, more than 750,000 manuscripts have already been digitally preserved.

Perhaps the most encouraging aspect of the initiative is the growing participation of ordinary citizens. Across the country, families are coming forward to share manuscripts that have been preserved for generations. Literary organisations, traditional institutions, and research centres are partnering with the government to support documentation and digitisation efforts.

This growing public engagement is transforming manuscript preservation from a specialised archival activity into a broader cultural movement. In an age increasingly shaped by digital technology, Gyan Bharatam offers a powerful reminder that innovation and tradition need not stand in opposition. By bringing ancient knowledge into digital formats, India is ensuring that its intellectual heritage remains relevant, discoverable, and accessible in the twenty-first century.

Every manuscript preserved is more than a document saved. It is a story recovered, a tradition remembered, and a piece of civilisational memory passed on to the future. From palm leaves to tablets, India is not merely digitising its past; it is reimagining its future through the wisdom of its heritage.

Views expressed are personal

PRADHAN REVIEWS RE-EXAM PREPAREDNESS

Stay calm, ignore rumours: NTA to NEET aspirants

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: With the NEET-UG 2026 re-examination just days away, the National Testing Agency (NTA) and the Union Education Ministry on Thursday stepped up efforts to reassure candidates and strengthen preparations for the nationwide test scheduled on June 21, following the cancellation of the original examination amid allegations of a paper leak.

In a message addressed to candidates, the NTA urged students to remain calm, avoid being influenced by rumours circulating on social media, and focus on their preparations. The agency clarified that the re-examination would be conducted as scheduled and advised aspirants to rely only on official communications.

"We want to reassure you that extensive arrangements are in place for a safe, secure and fair examination, in close coordination with relevant ministries, state governments and security



Union minister Dharmendra Pradhan chairs a review meeting to assess preparedness for NEET UG re-examination, in New Delhi

agencies," the NTA said. "The integrity of this process is our highest priority, and robust, multi-layered safeguards have been put in place."

The agency also issued a stern warning against malpractice, stating that any attempt to compromise the examination process would be dealt with firmly to protect the interests of honest and hardworking students.

The NEET-UG examination for admission to undergraduate medical courses was originally

conducted on May 3. However, it was cancelled by the NTA on May 12 following allegations of a paper leak. The Central Bureau of Investigation (CBI) is currently probing the matter.

Meanwhile, Union Education minister Dharmendra Pradhan chaired a high-level review meeting on Thursday with senior officials from the Ministry of Education, the NTA, state governments and higher education institutions to assess preparedness for the re-examination.

Guj: NEET aspirant dies by suicide

AHMEDABAD: A 17-year-old NEET aspirant allegedly died by suicide after jumping from the sixth-floor balcony of his apartment in Ahmedabad's Tragad area in the early hours of Thursday, police said.

According to police, the incident occurred around 2.55 am at the Aristo Anandam residential complex. A security guard spotted the teenager lying in the common area and alerted residents. He was rushed to a hospital, where doctors declared him dead.

The student was scheduled to appear for the NEET-UG re-examination on June 21. Police said no suicide note was found and investigations are underway to ascertain the circumstances behind the incident.

Emphasising the need to uphold the "highest standards of integrity, transparency and efficiency," Pradhan directed all concerned authorities to remain vigilant and ensure the smooth and fair conduct of the examination.

The minister announced that officers designated by the Ministry of Education would be deployed across states to coordinate examination-related activities and report directly to a command centre headed by

the NTA Director General. He also instructed state government nodal officers to ensure that students receive all necessary support and facilities to appear for the examination in a stress-free environment.

School Education and Literacy Secretary Sanjay Kumar, Higher Education Secretary Vineet Joshi and NTA Director General Abhishek Singh attended the meeting, along with senior officials from various states.

Kumar urged state authorities to take all necessary preparatory measures, while Joshi stressed that the remaining days before the examination were crucial and called for proactive coordination, timely dissemination of instructions and strict adherence to prescribed protocols.

Singh informed the meeting that the NTA is working closely with district-level coordination committees led by District Magistrates, as well as state police departments and intelligence agencies, to ensure smooth conduct of the examination.

Acknowledging the pressure faced by candidates, the NTA also highlighted the availability of the MANAS mental health helpline (14416) for students experiencing examination-related stress. The agency appealed to parents, teachers and the wider community to avoid spreading unverified information and help students approach the examination with confidence and peace of mind.

CBSE's '3-language' policy: SC refuses to pass interim order

Plea challenges policy's implementation

MPOST BUREAU

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court on Thursday refused to pass any interim order on a plea challenging the implementation of a CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages, including two native Indian languages, for Class 9 students from the 2026-27 academic session.

A bench of Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justice V Mohana tagged the plea filed by NGO Friends of People for Active Democracy with similar petitions pending on the issue.

"We cannot pass a single-line order today. This matter was argued at length. There is no question of interim protection," the bench said as it ordered the tagging of the matter.

During the brief hearing, the counsel appearing for the NGO submitted that they are not challenging the three-language policy per se but just the implementation part of it.

CJI Kant then questioned the NGO's name, Friends Of People For Active Democracy, and asked in a lighter vein if that kind of nomenclature was meant to create fear in the mind of the court or the people.

The counsel replied, "No, my lord. That's the name of the trust. It's an old trust set up in 2013", and submitted that the CBSE was required to issue detailed guidelines by June 15.

The bench, however, listed the matter for hearing on July 14 along with other pending petitions.

On May 27, the top court agreed to examine the plea challenging a CBSE policy mandating the study of three languages and issued notices to the Centre, the CBSE and the NCERT and sought comprehensive replies within two



weeks. It had asked ASG Aishwarya Bhati to submit a report on the logistical preparedness of the CBSE to implement the decision and posted the matter for hearing in the second week of July.

According to a recent circular issued by the Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), the study of three languages, including at least two native Indian languages, has been made compulsory for Class 9 students beginning July 1.

The move is part of the CBSE's alignment of its scheme of studies with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 and the National Curriculum Framework for School Education (NCF-SE) 2023.

"In order to adequately address the competencies envisaged at the Secondary Stage, these textbooks will be supplemented with one appropriate local or state literary material, selected by schools, such as short stories, poems, or nonfiction works," the board said. It added that detailed guidelines regarding the selection and pedagogical use of supplementary literary material would be issued by June 15.

According to the circular issued on May 15, students opting for a foreign language may do so only as the third language after studying two native Indian languages, or as an additional fourth language.

Shah reviews cooperative banking, export, organic farming initiatives

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: Union Home and Cooperation minister Amit Shah on Thursday reviewed a nationwide road-map to strengthen cooperative banks and promote organic farming and exports through the cooperative sector.

Chairing a high-level meeting, Shah emphasised the need for cooperative banks to adopt a unified digital infrastructure, enhance cybersecurity and standardise operations to improve efficiency and security. He directed that rural cooperative banks be integrated with the Sahkar Sarathi platform, while urban cooperative banks should align with the National Urban Cooperative Finance



and Development Corporation (NUCFDC).

Cybersecurity emerged as a key focus area. Officials discussed the integration of Mule-Hunter.AI with the Indian Cyber Crime Coordination Centre (I4C) to improve the detection and prevention of financial frauds across cooperative banking institutions. The move is expected to strengthen digital safeguards and reduce vulnerabilities in the sector.

The meeting was informed

that Sahkar Sarathi will roll out Aadhaar Enabled Payment System (AePS) services later this year. E-KYC services have already been introduced in some cooperative banks, with plans to extend the facility to 100 banks by August 2026.

Shah also reviewed the modernisation of urban cooperative banks through their gradual integration with NUCFDC, a step expected to provide access to advanced technology platforms and improved operational support.

The meeting further examined efforts to expand organic farming through cooperatives. The National Cooperative Organics Limited (NCOL) plans to increase procurement from organic farmers.

'Cartridge', stone retrieved from gang-rape victim's private parts

BEGUSARAI: A 30-year-old woman was allegedly gang-raped in Bihar's Begusarai district, with doctors treating her reportedly retrieving a cartridge-like object, a stone and a piece of wood from her private parts during medical examination days after the incident, officials said on Thursday.

According to the victim, the incident took place in Chakiya area on June 11 when she stepped out of her house to attend the nature's call.

The victim, in her police complaint, said five men overpowered her and dragged her to a secluded area, where they tied her hands and legs and raped her.

BIHAR HORROR

'Doctors treating her also retrieved a piece of wood from her private parts'

Begusarai Superintendent of Police Maneesh said, "A medical board has been constituted to examine the incident. The case is being probed from all angles and a Special Investigation Team (SIT) has been formed. A manhunt has been launched to nab the absconding accused."

The victim, in her complaint, alleged that the accused inflicted injuries on various parts of her body with a sharp object before abandoning her.

She received treatment and was discharged on June 12. Police registered the case soon after the incident, the SP said.

However, the victim said she continued to suffer pain even after returning home. She was taken back to the district hospital on June 17, where further medical examinations were conducted. Family members of the victim alleged that despite informing the police about the incident, no action has been taken against the accused.

Her family members also claimed that some of the accused had previously entered her house about three months ago, assaulted her and attempted to sexually assault her.

RAM MANDIR DONATION ROW

Ayodhya: 2021 land deal returns to spotlight

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

LUCKNOW: The ongoing investigation into the alleged embezzlement of donations at the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya has revived questions over a five-year-old land purchase by the Shri Ram Jannabhoomi Teerth Kshetra Trust, with Opposition parties alleging a pattern of financial irregularities since the Trust's formation.

The controversy erupted after Aam Aadmi Party leader Sanjay Singh and Samajwadi Party leader Pawan Pandey alleged that the Trust had paid an inflated price for the property. Citing land records, they claimed that the parcel in Bag Bijaisi village under Ayodhya's Sadar tehsil was purchased by property dealers Sultan Ansari



and Ram Mohan Tiwari from owner Kusum Pathak for Rs 2 crore.

"The same land was sold to the Ram Mandir Trust within minutes for Rs 18.5 crore," they alleged, claiming that both transactions were witnessed by the same two individuals, then Ayodhya Mayor Rishikesh Upadhyay and Trust member Anil Mishra.

The Opposition demanded a CBI and ED investigations into the issue, alleging corruption and possible money laundering. Trust General Secretary Champat Rai had dismissed the allegations, saying the purchase was carried out with complete transparency.

He argued that land prices in Ayodhya had surged sharply after the Supreme Court verdict,

particularly around key locations such as the railway station. According to Rai, the Trust purchased the land at Rs 1,423 per sq ft, which he claimed was below the prevailing market rate at the time.

Now, the controversy has resurfaced after the Uttar Pradesh government constituted a three-member Special Investigation Team to probe alleged embezzlement of donations collected at the Ram Mandir.

Samajwadi Party spokesperson Rajkumar Bhati recently referred to the land deal while questioning the Trust's financial transactions. He alleged that despite demands for an investigation in 2021, no action had been taken against those allegedly responsible.

653 ANTIQUITIES REPATRIATED SINCE 2014

India strengthens heritage preservation, expands global cultural footprint through major initiatives

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: India's vast and diverse heritage embodies thousands of years of history, culture, and tradition. Safeguarding it is central to preserving the nation's unique civilisational identity. In the past 12 years, the government has placed renewed emphasis on the conservation, development, and promotion of India's rich cultural legacy.

Key initiatives have focused on restoring iconic sites, improving visitor facilities, conserving ancient temples and monuments, and developing heritage cities and pilgrimage circuits. Programmes aimed at rejuvenating spiritual and cultural centres have helped preserve India's historic character while also enhancing public access and tourism potential.

At the same time, investments in connectivity, urban renewal, digital outreach, and tourism infrastructure around heritage destinations have contributed to local economic growth and employment gen-

KEY POINTS

- Key initiatives have focused on restoring iconic sites, improving visitor facilities, conserving ancient temples and monuments, and developing heritage cities and pilgrimage circuits
- Programmes aimed at rejuvenating spiritual



and cultural centres have helped preserve India's historic character while also enhancing public access and tourism potential

eration. Heritage-led development projects have encouraged sustainable tourism while ensuring that cultural assets are protected for future generations. India's cultural landscape includes monuments, antiquities, manuscripts, and historic sites. They are not just remnants of the past, but represent shared memory and continuity across generations. UNESCO World Heritage sites have increased from 33 to 44 and 15 Indian cultural traditions now enjoy UNESCO recognition.

Since 2014, the government

has launched several initiatives to preserve and promote these cultural assets. The government has also focused on linking heritage development with economic growth while strengthening India's global cultural identity. In addition, heritage conservation has increasingly been integrated with tourism, livelihoods, and cultural diplomacy, according to an official release.

Launched in September 2017 and revamped in September 2023, the Adopt a Heritage 2.0 programme creates a frame-

work for collaboration with private companies, public sector units, NGOs, trusts, and societies. It focuses on developing and maintaining visitor-friendly amenities at Protected Monuments of National Importance. Support is provided through Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) and other contributions. The aim is to improve the visitor experience.

As on March 2026, a total of 30 Memorandums of Understanding (MoUs) have been signed under the Adopt a Heritage 2.0 programme.

The programme is already demonstrating visible outcomes in terms of improved site management and enhanced public engagement. This is reflected in strong visitor participation at adopted monuments, which collectively recorded a total footfall of 13.59 million visitors during FY 2024-25.

The Gyan Bharatam Mission, launched in 2025, is the government's flagship initiative aimed at preserving, digitising, and disseminating India's vast manuscript heritage. It focuses

on preserving ancient knowledge systems recorded in manuscripts. It also makes them accessible for research and public engagement through digital repositories and conservation networks. The initiative further integrates modern technologies to safeguard these fragile manuscripts and ensure they are globally accessible. More than 8 lakh digitised manuscripts in different formats are being reformatted as per Gyan Bharatam Standard Operating Procedures (SOP). Out of these, 1.29 lakh manuscripts are accessible to the public on the National Digital Repository (NDR).

Additionally, the National Manuscript Survey was also launched in March 2026 for identifying, documenting and creating a comprehensive national database of manuscripts.

The government has been able to get 653 antiquities repatriated since 2014, restoring India's cultural treasures.

Under the National Film Heritage Mission, 1,469 films have been digitised.



CHANDIGARH: The Narcotics Control Bureau (NCB), in coordination with local police, has busted an alleged international drug trafficking network linked to Pakistan and operating across the Tricity region, officials said.

The operation was launched on June 12 after the NCB received specific intelligence about a suspected narcotics syndicate based in Kharar, Punjab. Acting on the information, officials intercepted a car and searched its occupant, a practising lawyer.

During the search, the NCB recovered 93 grams of methamphetamine, commonly known as "Ice", and 10 grams of heroin. Subsequent searches at a residence in Kharar led to the seizure of an additional 700 grams of methamphetamine and 250 grams of poppy straw.

With the latest recovery, the total seizure in the case stands at 793 grams of methamphetamine, 10 grams of heroin and 250 grams of poppy straw.

A co-accused residing with the main suspect was also arrested. Investigators believe the individual played

an active role in the distribution network.

Officials said the quantity of methamphetamine seized is nearly 16 times the commercial quantity prescribed under the Narcotic Drugs and Psychotropic Substances (NDPS) Act. Preliminary investigations indicate that the drug supply chain was linked to a Pakistan-based trafficking syndicate.

The NCB said further investigations are underway to identify other members of the network and trace both the source and destination of the seized narcotics. Authorities are also examining interstate and international links to uncover the full extent of the trafficking operation.

Officials described the bust as a major success in the ongoing crackdown against organised drug smuggling networks operating in the region.

MAJOR ATTACK ON MOSCOW

Ukraine bombs Russian oil refinery

Some areas in the city have reported fuel shortages

MOSCOW: Ukraine struck a major Moscow oil refinery Thursday for a second time in a week, sending huge plumes of black smoke over the capital and disrupting flights at its airports in one of its biggest drone attacks since Russia's full-scale invasion over four years ago, officials said.

Ukraine has repeatedly targeted Russian oil facilities, aiming to cut Moscow's revenue for the war and make Russians feel the consequences of the invasion. Some areas have reported fuel shortages.

The attack by dozens of drones came hours after Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said he had held "an important coordination call" with the presidents of the United States and France and had won key pledges of further support from this week's G7 summit.

"If Ukraine is going to burn, your Moscow will burn too," Zelenskyy said, adding that the attack was part of Kyiv's effort to bring Russian President Vladimir Putin to the negotiating table. "It is time to end the aggression, time to end this war."

Zelenskyy was expected to hold talks in Brussels later Thursday with NATO and European Union leaders, including about the possibility of a continental system to defend against ballistic missiles. Russia has relentlessly struck Ukraine with those types of missiles, which air defences struggle to counter.

The Moscow attack was the latest embarrassment for Putin, after a Ukrainian drone attack on his hometown of St Petersburg earlier this month as he welcomed foreign VIPs to his showcase economic forum in the city.

Thick, black smoke and occasional flames spewed from the Moscow Oil Refinery amid its red-and-white smokestacks on the southeastern edge of the city, about 15 kilometres (9 miles) from the Kremlin. Sooty, black rain fell on cars, according to local video.

"One of the most popular questions asked by Muscovites this morning is What is going



Thick, black smoke and occasional flames spewed from refinery

Highlights

- » The attack by dozens of drones came hours after Zelenskyy said he had held 'an important coordination call' with US, France Presidents
- » Zelenskyy was expected to hold talks in Brussels later Thursday with NATO and EU leaders

on?" Ukrainian Foreign Minister Andrii Sybiha said in a post on X.

"I can answer. Your country started a war of aggression against ours. For years, it has been killing our people. Now that you know what's going on, ask Putin when he is planning to end it."

The refinery is one of Russia's biggest, according to its official website and produces more than a third of the Moscow region's fuel.

It was last attacked by Ukrainian drones on Tuesday,

catching fire, but officials said the blaze was swiftly put out.

Thursday's fire at the refinery was "largely contained," Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyannin said, adding that remaining hotspots were being extinguished.

As Ukraine pressed its strikes on Russia's energy infrastructure, fuel supplies appeared to be under strain. Gas station chains in multiple regions have introduced restrictions on what drivers could buy.

Russian independent news outlet Agentstvo reported that one in every four gas stations in the country has introduced some kind of restrictions.

Authorities in the capital said in a statement hours after the attack that "supplies of oil products to Moscow and the work of all gas stations in the city continue as normal."

The attack also temporarily halted flights from four Moscow airports, transport and aviation authorities said. AGENCIES

Mediator Pak signs US-Iran peace memorandum

Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif says Hormuz to reopen instantly

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif on Thursday signed the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding - aimed at restoring peace in West Asia - as the key mediator of the negotiations, his office said.

The document was already signed by US President Donald Trump and Iranian President Masoud Pezeshkian on Wednesday.

Sharif's signing of the Memorandum of Understanding (MoU) - in which Washington and Tehran are the two main parties - comes a day ahead of a planned ceremony in Switzerland, where key negotiators from the US, Iran, Pakistan and Qatar are expected to gather. Pakistan has officially signed as a guarantor.

"Prime Minister of Pakistan Muhammad Shehbaz Sharif signed the Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding as a guarantor. Signatures of US President Donald Trump and Iran's President Masoud Pezeshkian are present on the



Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif signs as mediator on a paper which the office said was a copy of the initial deal reached by the United States and Iran to end their war on Thursday

Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding," Sharif's office said in a post on X.

The Prime Minister's Office on Thursday also shared photographs and videos of him signing the document.

Earlier in the day, Sharif hailed Trump and Iran's Supreme Leader Mojtaba Khamenei for restoring peace in West Asia, as he announced

that the signing of the document will instantly reopen the Strait of Hormuz and the US will immediately lift its naval blockade.

Trump on Wednesday signed the memorandum of understanding at the Palace of Versailles in France, where he had dinner with French President Emmanuel Macron after the G7 summit. Later, Iranian

“THE DOCUMENT WAS ALREADY SIGNED BY US PRESIDENT AND IRANIAN PRESIDENT MASOUD PEZESHKIAN ON WEDNESDAY”

media posted photos of President Pezeshkian holding a copy of the signed document before a camera.

Sharif on Thursday said that the signing of the agreement at the highest level of the respective governments demonstrates the commitment of both sides to a diplomatic resolution of the conflict, as he thanked West Asian countries such as Saudi Arabia, Qatar, Türkiye and Egypt for their contribution.

The peace process was negotiated through mediators that included Pakistan and Qatar, who initially got a two-week ceasefire agreement on

April 8. The ceasefire was later extended till the completion of the talks. Pakistan - which eventually emerged as the key mediator - hosted the first round of peace talks in April, which was attended by senior leaders from both sides, but they failed to clinch a deal.

"I am honoured to announce that the historic 'Islamabad Memorandum of Understanding' has been electronically signed today between the United States of America and the Islamic Republic of Iran," Sharif said in a post on X earlier on Thursday.

He further said: "Islamabad MoU shall enter into force with immediate effect and as a first step, the Islamic Republic of Iran will instantly reopen the Strait of Hormuz and the United States of America will immediately lift the naval blockade."

The Strait of Hormuz is a narrow waterway through which roughly one-fifth of the world's total energy supplies pass in normal times. AGENCIES

ASEAN SUMMIT IN RUSSIA

Putin, leaders of Southeast Asia agree to bolster relations

MOSCOW: President Vladimir Putin on Thursday hailed Russia's ties with the Association of Southeast Asian Nations as he hosted a summit intended to strengthen economic and political ties with the bloc. The leaders who took part in the meeting in Kazan agreed to further expand "strategic partnership" between Russia and ASEAN nations that include Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, East Timor and Vietnam.

"It is a strategic partner-

ASEAN nations include Brunei, Cambodia, Indonesia, Laos, Malaysia, Myanmar, the Philippines, Singapore, Thailand, East Timor and Vietnam

ship that serves as an essential stabilising factor in the Asia-Pacific amidst geopolitical turbulence, contributing to the formation of a balanced security architecture and equitable mutually beneficial cooperation," Putin said at the summit, which marked the 35th anniversary of Russia-ASEAN rela-

tions. The summit's agenda included exchanging views on global and regional issues, reviewing efforts to develop Russia-ASEAN ties and discussing areas and tasks for future cooperation.

Putin noted that Russia and ASEAN have "expanded the scope of practical cooperation. AGENCIES

'Israeli forces will stay in Lebanon as long as Israel requires it'

TYRE: Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu said on Thursday that Israel's military will stay in southern Lebanon, where it has occupied up to 10 kilometres from the border.

The remarks were his first comment since the US-Iran deal was signed. Netanyahu said Israel must "maintain a security zone in southern Lebanon, and it requires that we must not leave there as long as Israel's security needs require it."

He has made similar comments in the past about Israel's refusal to withdraw from southern Lebanon.

The US-Iran deal to end the war in the Middle East, signed overnight, also calls for an end to the war in Lebanon, where Israel has been fighting the militant Hezbollah group, but it's unclear what that means in practice.

Lebanon's state-run National News Agency reported several Israeli drone strikes on Thursday morning in the country's south, including one on a car in the town of Kfar Tebnit that killed one person and critically wounded another.

The Israel-Hezbollah war has displaced more than 1 million people in Lebanon, and killed nearly 3,900, according to Lebanese officials. AGENCIES

BEFORE THE LD. SOLE ARBITRATOR, MR. DEVANSH GUPTA, (ADVOCATE) AT DELHI INTERNATIONAL ARBITRATION CENTRE (DIAC)
Ph:-011-23386492, 23386480
DIAC REF. NO. DIAC/2024/12-25

IN THE MATTER OF :
MONEYWISE FINANCIAL SERVICES PVT. LTD.
(Through its Authorised Representatives)CLAIMANT

VERSUS
RONIT TRADING CO. & ORS.
.....RESPONDENTS
NOTICE OF HEARING

To,
1. RONIT TRADING CO.
Through its Proprietor Mr. Nikhil Gupta
At:- 19/173, Sarai Basti, Old Rohtak Road,
Sarai Rohilla, Delhi-110035.
Email:ronittradingcompany@gmail.com,
nikhilguptaronit981@gmail.com
Also at:- 90/6, Gali no.07,A,Mundaka,
Udyog Nagar, South Side, North-West,
Delhi-110041

Mr. NIKHIL GUPTA
S/O VIJAY KUMAR GUPTA
28/15 First Floor, Shakti Nagar, Malika
Ganj, Delhi-110007
Email:ronittradingcompany@gmail.com,
nikhilguptaronit981@gmail.com
Also At:-F-13/A2,Ground Floor, Plot No
2, KH. NO 462,Nasipur Road, Mahavir
Enclave, Delhi-110045

2. MRS.NALINI GUPTA
At: 28/15 First Floor,Shakti Nagar, Malika
Ganj Delhi-110007

Also at: Plot No-59,BKL-G-Lawrence
Road, Industrial Area Keshavpuram
Delhi-110035

PLEASE TAKE NOTICE that the hearing in the above Arbitration case filed by the claimant Moneywise Financial Services Pvt.Ltd is fixed before the undersigned on 01.07.2026 at 2:00 to 3:00 PM, through Video Conferencing at S-Block, Delhi International Arbitration Centre, New Delhi. You are, therefore, directed to appear in the above noted case either personally or through your duly authorized representative on the date and time fixed through Virtual mode. The link for the hearing can be obtained by emailing on dc16@diac.ind.in. PLEASE NOTE that in case you fail to appear and attend the matter on the date and time given above, the matter will be proceeded with in your absence and shall be decided in accordance with law.

sd/-
MR. DEVANSH GUPTA
(Sole Arbitrator)
Celeste Agarwal
Deputy Counsel
Place: New Delhi Ph:-011-23386492,
Date: 09.06.2026 23386480.

GOVERNMENT OF JAMMU AND KASHMIR
Jammu and Kashmir Power Transmission Corporation Ltd
Office of the Executive Engineer
Transmission Line Maintenance Division-I (TLMD-I), Bemina, Srinagar
Ph. No. 0194-2492427; E-mail ID: tlmd1-bemina@jk.gov.in,
TENDER NOTICE
e-NIT No.: 03/JKPTCL/TLMD-I/SGR/2026-27; Dated: 18.06.2026

For and on behalf of the Lt. Governor of UT of Jammu & Kashmir, e-Tenders (in Two Covers) from Government approved, reputed, experienced, competent and financially sound electrical Contractors/Firms/Suppliers/Joint Ventures/Executors/OEMs fulfilling the eligibility criteria specified in the standard bidding document are invited online for supply of the material as detailed in the BoQ.

e-Tenders need to be accompanied with a non-refundable Tender Fee in the form of Demand Draft pledged to Executive Engineer, Transmission Line Maintenance Division-I, Bemina, Srinagar for Rs. 1000.00 (Rupees One Thousand Only) on account of Cost of Tender Document and EMD amounting to Rs. 5000.00 (Five Thousand only) in the form of CDR/ FDR/ BG as security deposit pledged to Executive Engineer, TLMD-I, Bemina.

Cover-I: The bidding process is online. However, hardcopies consisting of Tender fee and EMD in accordance with General Terms and conditions of SBD (original instruments) in cover-1 should reach to the office of Executive Engineer, TLMD-I, Bemina, Srinagar one day after the last date for online submission of e-Bid.

Cover-II: However, after opening of the tenders on-line, L1 Bidder will be called to submit his/her Original/Photocopies of documents viz. relevant documents valid and renewed contractor License /Labour Registration Certificate, GST registration, PAN card, TIN No. and all other documents related to the bid for synchronization with Techno commercial evaluation. Cover-III: The bidder shall upload online rates as per detailed BOQ enclosed as Annexure-A. The rates shall be inclusive of all taxes etc.

The Standard Bidding Document shall be kept available at website <https://www.jktenders.gov.in>

S. No	Scope of the Work	Tender Fe	EMD	Time Completion of
1	Rate Contract for supply of electrical spares and minor store/hardware items, as given in the detailed BoQ, from Government approved, reputed, experienced, competent and financially sound electrical Contractors/Firms/Suppliers/Joint Ventures/ Executors/ OEMs or registered firms already in the trade	Rs. 1000.00	Rs. 5000.00	15 Days from the date of issuance of supply order

The information regarding schedule of downloading of the tender document, seeking of clarifications and submission dates thereof is as per the table below

CRITICAL DATES SCHEDULE

1	Issue of NIT	18.06.2026
2	Downloading of bidding documents (Start)	18.06.2026(02:00PM)
3	Start date for seeking clarifications	18.06.2026(02:00PM)
4	End date for seeking clarifications	20.06.2026(04:00PM)
5	End date for replies to clarifications	22.06.2026(04:00PM)
6	E-Bid submission (start) date & time (uploading of e-tender fee, EMD and other supporting documents in PDF formats)	18.06.2026(02:00PM)
7	e-Bid submission (end) date & time (Submission of e-tender fee, bid security and other supporting documents in PDF formats)	09.07.2026(02:00PM)
8	Last date for submission of Hard Copy of e-Bid	10.07.2026(04:00PM)
9	Online Techno-Commercial e-Bid opening date and time.	11.07.2026(02:00PM)
10	Venue of opening of Techno-Commercial-Bids	Office of the Executive Engineer, TLMD-I, Bemina
11	Cost of e-Bid document	Rs. 1000.00
12	EMD	Rs. 5000.00

- Only the bidders possessing the qualifying criteria as mentioned in the SBD should participate in the bidding process
- Clarifications can be sought from the office of the under signed or on e-Mail address: tlmd1-bemina@jk.gov.in
- The Corporation (JKPTCL) reserves the right to reject any or all the bids without assigning any reason therefor.
- The Bidders are advised to furnish and upload complete bidder address including address of place of business along with all valid Landline/Mobile Nos /fax Nos plus e-mailing addresses.

No: TLMD-I/TS/03A/26-27/899-903
Dated: 18.06.2026
DIP No:DIPK-NB-803/26

Sd/- Executive Engineer,
Transmission Line Maintenance Division-I,
Transmission (Kashmir), JKPTCL, Bemina, Sgr

NORTHERN RAILWAY
NOTICE FOR TENDER AT GEM PORTAL

Senior Divisional Commercial Manager/F.S, Delhi Division, Northern Railway, in terms of Railway Board letter no. 2025/TC(FM)/11/20 dated 17.11.2025, invites bids through tender at Gem Portal (<https://gem.gov.in>) for the work of outsourcing of handling of booked parcels and luggage packages along with other activities in terms of FM Circular 26 of 2025 dated 17.11.2025 for Delhi Sarai Rohilla (DEE) station for a period of 03 years with BID NO: GEM/2026/B/7657541 as per detail and schedule given below:-

S. No.	Bid End Date and Time	Bid Opening Date and Time	Pre-Bid Meeting Date and Time	Approximate Cost (inclusive of all taxes)	Earnest Money Deposit	Period of Contract	Name of Work and completion period
1	07.07.2026 at 14:00 hrs.	07.07.2026 at 14:30 hrs.	25.06.2026 at 15:00 hrs.	Rs. 4,00,94,394/- (Rupees Four Crore Ninety Four Thousand Three Hundred Ninety Four)	Rs. 3,50,480/- (Rupees Three Lacs Fifty Thousand Four Hundred Eighty)	03 years	Tender/BID No.: GEM/2026/B/7657541 Name of Work: Tender at Gem Portal (https://gem.gov.in) through tender/BID No.: GEM/2026/B/7657541 for the work of outsourcing of handling of booked parcels and luggage packages along with other activities in terms of FM Circular 26 of 2025 for Delhi Sarai Rohilla (DEE) station for a period of 03 years.

Important notes: 1. For more information, requirement and various aspects of the tender including registration on Gem portal, how to participate in tenders at gem portal, interested bidders are advised to visit <https://gem.gov.in>. 2. Tender document can be downloaded from <https://bidplus.gem.gov.in/bids> by entering bid no. GEM/2026/B/7657541 in the search option. 3. Railway Administration reserves the full and absolute rights to cancel/terminate this tender/contract at any point of time and/or for taking any decision regarding the discontinuation/continuation of this contract with modified/additional terms and conditions depending upon their successful execution or any other modified rule issued by Railways in this regard. 4. Prospective bidders are advised, in their own interest, to visit Delhi Sarai Rohilla Station to analyse the scope of work before bidding. No.: NR-DL10COMM(PARC)/31/2026-Freight Cell 2094/2026

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE

ICICI Bank Branch Office: ICICI Bank Ltd., 4/10, Mythree Tower, Bormanhalli Hosur Main Road Bangalore- 560068

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice. Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand Notice (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Perka Naveen/ Peruka Anjamma/ LBKRN00005738565 LBKRN00006480257	(As Described In The Loan Document / Property Document Covering All That Part And Parcel of Open Plot No.91 (Part) In Sy.No.219, Out of Which An Extent of 240.00 Sq. Yards, Equal To 200.66 Sq. Metres, situated At Rangampalli Village Locality of Municipality Peddapalli, Mandal Parishad Peddapalli, District: Peddapalli, Within The Registration District Karimnagar, Sub District Peddapalli, Is Bounded By Bounded By: North: Open Place of Others South: Open Plot No. 91 (Part) of Gurrula Sadanandam East:24 Wide Plot Road West: Open Plot No.104 of Barupati Mallahia/ Symbolic Possession on/ 15/06/2026.	07.03.2026 Rs. 38,09,912.66/-	Karimnagar

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: June 19, 2026
Place: Delhi

Sincerely Authorised Officer,
For ICICI Bank Ltd.

UT of Jammu & Kashmir
Office of the Executive Engineer, Trans. Line Maintn. Division-VII,
JKPTCL Bemina, Srinagar-190010
Ph. No. 0194-3516481 e-mail: tlmd-vii.sgr@jk.gov.in

EXTENSION NOTICE-I

The last date for submission of bids in respect of tender e-NIT No. TLMD7/05 of 2026-27 dated: 12-05-2026 for "Augmentation of Grid Station Alusteng from 320MVA to 475 MVA at 220/132kV level alongwith allied works" is hereby extended with revised critical dates as under

1	Existing e-bids submission end date and time	17-06-2026 (14:00 Hrs.)
2	Extended e-bids submission end date and time	24-06-2026 (14:00 Hrs.)
3	Online techno commercial e-bid opening date and time	27-06-2026 (12:00 Hrs.)

All other terms and conditions of e-NIT will remain unchanged.

No. TLMD-7/TS/916-21
Dated: 17.06.2026
DIP No:DIPK-NB-808/26

Sd/-
Executive Engineer,
TLMD-VII, Bemina
Srinagar

SBI & DMART FOUNDER DAMANI AMONG BIGGEST BENEFICIARIES

NSE IPO: Existing shareholders to reap gains worth thousands of cores

OUR CORRESPONDENT

NEW DELHI: The much-awaited initial public offering (IPO) of the National Stock Exchange (NSE) is set to unlock significant value for its existing shareholders, with institutional investors, financial entities and industry veterans expected to reap gains worth thousands of cores.

The country's largest stock exchange on Wednesday filed its draft papers with market regulator Sebi for its mega-IPO, estimated at around Rs 30,000 crore.

The offering, which will be entirely an Offer for Sale (OFS), is set to become the largest public issue in Indian stock market history.

At the estimated size, the NSE share-sale will surpass the Rs 27,870 crore IPO of Hyundai Motor India, which was launched in October 2024 and currently holds the record of the biggest IPO in the country.

Based on the prevailing unlisted market price of around Rs 2,000 per share, billionaire investor and DMart founder Radhakishan Damani's 3.91 crore shares, representing a 1.58 per cent stake in NSE, are valued at about Rs 7,817 crore, making him one of the biggest individual beneficiaries of the proposed listing.

Hero Enterprise Chairman Sunil Kant Munjal's 1.02



DMart founder Radhakishan Damani's 3.91 crore shares, representing a 1.58 per cent stake in NSE, are valued at about Rs 7,817 crore, making him one of the biggest individual beneficiaries

crore shares, or a 0.41 per cent stake, are worth around Rs 2,040 crore, while Infosys co-founder S Gopalakrishnan's 94.29 lakh shares, representing a 0.38 per cent holding, are valued at nearly Rs 1,886 crore.

Individual investor Siddharth Balachandran's 0.38 per cent stake is estimated to be worth about Rs 1,863 crore at current unlisted market valuations.

The IPO comprises the sale of 14.89 crore shares by existing shareholders, who will collectively divest nearly 6 per cent of their stake in the exchange.

Among selling shareholders,

State Bank of India (SBI) is expected to emerge as the largest beneficiary.

The country's largest lender plans to offload 2.47 crore shares, potentially generating nearly Rs 4,950 crore based on current unlisted market prices.

Notably, SBI's weighted average acquisition cost stands at just 80 paise per share, suggesting the substantial appreciation the NSE has generated over the years.

Mauritius-based MS Strategic is expected to realise around Rs 3,200 crore through the sale of 1.6 crore shares, while Canadian pension fund CPPIB

Highlights

- » Hero Enterprise Chairman Sunil Kant Munjal's 1.02 crore shares, or a 0.41 per cent stake, are worth around Rs 2,040 crore
- » While Infosys co-founder S Gopalakrishnan's 94.29 lakh shares, representing a 0.38 per cent holding, are valued at nearly Rs 1,886 crore
- » Individual investor Siddharth Balachandran's 0.38% stake is estimated to be worth about Rs 1,863 cr

could garner around Rs 2,375 crore. Aranda Investments is likely to sell shares worth nearly Rs 2,250 crore.

Other major sellers include Bank of Baroda, which could receive around Rs 2,197 crore, followed by Stock Holding Corporation of India (Rs 2,178 crore), General Insurance Corporation of India (Rs 2,131 crore), and The New India Assurance Company Ltd (Rs 2,100 crore).

National Insurance Company and United India Insurance Company are each expected to realise nearly Rs 1,200 crore from the share sale.

According to industry estimates, the proposed IPO could value National Stock Exchange (NSE) at more than Rs 5 lakh crore, making it one of the most valuable listed financial market infrastructure institutions globally.

The filing marks a major milestone for NSE, whose listing plans had remained stalled for nearly a decade due to regulatory challenges, including issues arising from the co-location controversy.

According to market experts, NSE's shares are currently trading above Rs 2,050 in the unlisted market, implying a price-to-earnings multiple of around 50 times.

"The current unlisted market pricing at above Rs 2,050 (P/E- 50 times) appears significantly stretched, especially after a 15 per cent PAT decline in FY26 driven by Sebi's regulatory curbs on retail derivatives participation. We believe a fair IPO price discovery should be in the range of Rs 800- Rs 1,050, implying a reasonable 20-25x P/E on trailing earnings — more aligned with exchange business fundamentals globally," Rajesh Singla, CEO and Fund Manager at Alpha AMC, said.

He, further, said that investors holding unlisted shares at elevated valuations should factor in meaningful listing discount risk.

‘Adani keen on Hooghly tunnel, power, infra projects in Bengal’

KOLKATA: The Adani Group is looking to expand its presence in West Bengal, with interests in infrastructure projects, including a tunnel under the Hooghly river, and seeking a transparent policy framework to boost investments in the state, a company official said on Thursday.

The group remains open to make formal submissions to the state government on policy measures required to attract investment, he said.

"Kolkata has a traffic problem, and an under-river tunnel can connect the city with a high-way and support smooth cargo movement. We are very keen on such a project," the Adani Group official said, adding that such initiatives align with the group's core competencies in executing large-scale infrastructure developments.

A proposed tunnel under the Hooghly river is aimed at easing Kolkata's transport bottlenecks. Notably, the city has India's first underwater metro rail services, linking Kolkata and Howrah.

The Adani Group is interested in "every sort of major infrastructure projects" in West Bengal, the official said, describing improved connectivity as a key driver of economic growth and industrial development.

He also emphasised a structured stakeholder consultation process to formulate investment-friendly policies and attract investors.

"Stakeholder meetings can be called so that the process remains above board, everyone's views can be considered,



‘The group remains open to make formal submissions to the state govt on policy measures required to attract investment’

suggestions can be taken and then converted into policies," the official said.

On power generation and distribution, he said the group is keen to expand its footprint in the state as "opportunities exist in this sector".

According to industry analysts, the new BJP government in the state might open up opportunities for private investment in transmission and distribution.

"The introduction of more players brings competition and improves the quality," the official said, adding that the group would evaluate power distribution, provided a level-playing field is ensured.

The group has already said it would evaluate the deep-sea port opportunity in the state.

"A deep-sea port is an opportunity, but such mega projects come with their own

Key Points

- » A proposed tunnel under the Hooghly river is aimed at easing Kolkata's transport bottlenecks
- » The Adani Group is interested in 'every sort of major infrastructure projects' in West Bengal, company official said
- » The Adani Group has already said it would evaluate the deep-sea port opportunity in the state

set of challenges, including environmental clearances and jurisdictional issues involving both the Centre and the state," the official explained.

The West Bengal government has shifted the proposed Tajpur deep-sea port project site to Dadanpatra in Purba Medinipur district.

Emphasising the group's execution-oriented approach, the official said, "We believe in doing work. The company's focus remains on delivering projects rather than making announcements."

Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone Ltd has secured a five-year operation and maintenance contract for the container facility at Syama Prasad Mookerjee Port, Kolkata. The group also has a presence in the cement sector and is planning a hyperscale data centre in the city.

AGENCIES

NSE appoints record 20 merchant bankers for proposed ₹30K cr IPO

MUMBAI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has appointed a record 20 Book Running Lead Managers (BRLMs) or Merchant Bankers for its proposed Rs 30,000 crore IPO, underscoring the scale and significance of what is expected to be India's largest public issue.

According to the DRHP, the proposed IPO will be structured entirely as an Offer for Sale (OFS), involving up to 111.42 million equity shares by existing shareholders. As the issue is an OFS, the proceeds from the share sale will accrue to the selling shareholders, while NSE itself will not receive any fresh capital from the offering.

The list of merchant bankers mentioned in NSE's Draft Red Herring Prospectus (DRHP) for its long-awaited public listing.

The exchange has appointed a diverse syndicate of domestic

and global investment banks and financial institutions to manage the issue. The BRLMs include Kotak Mahindra Capital Company, JM Financial, Morgan Stanley India Company (marketing only), Anand Rath Advisors, Avendus Capital, Axis Capital, DAM Capital Advisors, Equirus Capital, HDFC Bank, ICICI Securities (marketing only), IDBI Capital Markets & Securities, IIFL Capital Services, Motilal Oswal Investment Advisors, Nuvama Wealth Management, Pantomath Capital Advisors and 360 ONE WAM (marketing only).

The appointment of 20 BRLMs marks the largest syndicate ever assembled for an IPO

in India, reflecting the expected size of the issue as well as strong investor interest in securing allocations and participation in the landmark offering.

NSE enters the IPO process from a position of financial strength. For FY26, the exchange reported revenue of approximately Rs 166 billion and a net profit of around Rs 103 billion, highlighting its dominant position in India's capital market ecosystem.

The broad-based syndicate comprising leading domestic and international investment banks is likely to ensure wide investor outreach across institutional, high-net-worth and retail segments, while supporting marketing efforts for what could become one of the most consequential public offerings in the history of the Indian stock market.

ANI

NSE flags regulatory, AI, tech risks in IPO papers

NEW DELHI: The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has cautioned investors about regulatory, technology, cybersecurity and artificial intelligence (AI)-related risks in its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) filed for its proposed IPO.

The exchange said transaction charges contributed 78.65 per cent of its operating revenue in FY26, with op-tions trading alone accounting for 60.22 per cent. It warned that tighter regulations, higher transaction taxes, changing investor preferences or a shift towards alternative asset classes could hurt trading volumes and profitability.

NSE noted that recent measures by the Sebi to strengthen the equity derivatives framework have already moderated trading activity and revenue growth. It also highlighted ongoing regulatory scrutiny

and disclosed receiving show-cause notices, warning letters and other communications from Sebi on governance, technology and compliance matters.

The bourse identified technology failures and cyberattacks as major operational risks, citing past incidents including a trading halt in February 2021 and a DDoS attack in May 2025. NSE also flagged emerging AI-related risks, warning that flawed algorithms, AI-powered cyberattacks, deepfakes and increasing use of algorithmic trading could lead to operational disruptions, market volatility and compliance challenges.

The exchange further pointed to concentration risks, with its top 10 trading members contributing 46.78 per cent of operating revenue in FY26.

AGENCIES

Emirates NBD to hold 60% in RBL Bank, board clears ₹26,015 cr shares

NEW DELHI: RBL Bank on Thursday said it will allot equity shares worth Rs 26,015 crore to Emirates NBD Bank, and has classified the Dubai-based bank as a promoter with a 60 per cent holding.

In a regulatory filing, RBL Bank said its board has approved the allotment of over 92.91 crore equity shares at Rs 280/share, aggregating to Rs 26,015 crore by way of a preferential issue on a private placement basis.

"Emirates NBD Bank (P.J.S.C) has been classified as a promoter of the Bank," RBL Bank said in the filing. Also, RBL Bank has approved the reconstruction of its board.

Shayne Keith Nelson, Patrick John Sullivan, Neeraj Makin, Manoj Chawla and



Marwan Mahmood Mohammad Hadi have been appointed as (Additional) Non-Executive Non-Independent Directors on the RBL Bank board with effect from June 18. They will be the nominees of Emirates NBD Bank on RBL's board.

Besides, Gopal Jain and Veena Mankar have resigned as non-executive non-independent directors of the Bank, with effect from Thursday.

Shares of RBL Bank were trading at Rs 372.25, up 0.92

per cent over the previous close on BSE.

In April, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) had allowed Emirates NBD Bank to acquire up to 74 per cent stake in RBL Bank, while the finance ministry gave its approval in May. The approval was granted following Emirates NBD Bank, the second largest in the UAE, expressing its interest in October 2025 to acquire a majority 60 per cent stake in RBL Bank for Rs 26,853 crore.

Emirates NBD (ENBD) would acquire and maintain a shareholding of at least 51 per cent of the paid-up share capital of RBL Bank, and the bank would be classified as a foreign bank in subsidiary mode, with the investor as its parent foreign bank.

PTI

Andersen Global joins hands with JMP Advisors to boost India presence

NEW DELHI: Andersen Global has expanded its presence in India through a collaboration agreement with tax and regulatory advisory firm JMP Advisors, strengthening its capabilities in one of the world's fastest-growing major economies.

The partnership will enhance Andersen Global's ability to provide tax, regulatory, transaction advisory and business consulting services in India, while offering multinational clients access to local expertise and cross-border advisory solutions, according to a joint statement.

Founded by tax expert Jairaj Purandare, JMP Advisors advises domestic and international clients on international and domestic taxation, transfer pricing, foreign investment, cross-border structuring, transaction support, succession planning and regulatory compliance.

The firm serves multinational corporations, private equity and venture capital-backed companies, growing businesses, and high-net-worth individuals navigating complex regulatory and business environments.

MP0ST

Net I-T collection climbs 14.64% to over ₹5.21 lakh cr till June 17 in FY27

NEW DELHI: Net direct tax collections grew 14.64 per cent year-on-year to Rs 5.21 lakh crore as of June 17 in the current financial year, driven by robust growth in both corporate and non-corporate tax receipts, according to official data released on Thursday.

Net corporate tax collections rose 22.47 per cent to Rs 2.08 lakh crore, while non-corporate tax collections, including taxes paid by individuals, HUFs, firms and other entities, increased 8.4 per cent to Rs 2.94 lakh crore.

Collections from Securities Transaction Tax (STT) jumped to Rs 18,856 crore from



Rs 13,013 crore in the corresponding period last year.

Tax refunds issued during the period rose marginally by 1.19 per cent to Rs 89,026 crore.

Gross direct tax collections increased 12.46 per cent to Rs 6.10 lakh crore, compared with Rs 5.42 lakh crore a year earlier.

Gross corporate tax receipts stood at Rs 2.77 lakh crore, while non-corporate tax collections were Rs 3.15 lakh crore.

Advance tax collections registered a healthy 15.3 per cent growth to Rs 1.78 lakh crore.

Corporate advance tax payments rose 16.01 per cent to Rs 1.41 lakh crore, while non-corporate advance tax collections increased 12.73 per cent to Rs 37,620 crore.

The strong rise in advance tax receipts is viewed as an early sign of healthy income growth and profitability among taxpayers in the current fiscal year.

AGENCIES

Pune Metro Line 3 completes end-to-end trials, bringing project closer to commercial operations

PUNE: Pune Metro Line 3, also known as the Puneri Metro, has successfully completed end-to-end trial runs across its 23-km elevated corridor connecting Hinjawadi and Shivajinagar, bringing the project closer to the start of commercial operations.

The corridor has achieved all major construction and system milestones. Viaduct work, track laying, third-rail electrification and signalling installation have been completed across the route, while all 23 stations are structurally ready and entry-exit works are in advanced stages.

Rolling stock has also cleared RDSO oscillation trials and received approvals from the Commissioner of Metro Rail Safety (CMRS) and the Minis-



try of Railways for operations at speeds of up to 85 kmph.

The project will be commissioned in phases. The first phase, covering a 13.3-km stretch between Maan and R K Laxman Museum with 12 stations, is targeted for opening by June 2026, subject to statutory clearances. The corridor will later be extended to District Court

station for integration with the Maha Metro network.

Once fully operational, the metro is expected to cut travel time between Shivajinagar and Hinjawadi to about 45 minutes from the current 90 minutes, reducing journey time by over 50 per cent.

Pune IT City Metro Rail Ltd (PITCMRL) CEO Anil Kumar

Saini said the project would provide seamless connectivity between Pune's city centre and IT hub, benefiting daily commuters, especially IT professionals, students and residents. He added that the metro would help ease road congestion and promote a shift towards sustainable public transport.

The project features CBTC signalling. Make-in-India rolling stock, smart ticketing systems and sustainability initiatives such as rooftop solar panels, rainwater harvesting and EV charging facilities. In a first-of-its-kind initiative, trains on the corridor will be operated by an all-women cadre, with nearly 100 women train operators already recruited.

MP0ST

VIT alumnus Saurabh Kumar Pal secures 110th Rank in Indian Forest Service Exam

VELLORE: Saurabh Kumar Pal, a 2022 B.Tech Computer Science graduate from Vellore Institute of Technology (VIT), has secured the 110th rank in the UPSC's Indian Forest Service (IFS) examination.

A native of Prayagraj, Uttar Pradesh, Pal dedicated himself to preparing for the prestigious examination after completing his engineering studies.

Congratulating him on the achievement, VIT Chancellor Dr. G. Viswanathan, along with Vice-Presidents Sankar Viswanathan and Sekar Viswanathan, extended their best wishes.

Dr. Viswanathan said VIT alumni continue to excel in



Saurabh Kumar Pal

national-level competitive examinations, adding that Pal's success serves as an inspiration for engineering graduates aspiring to join the civil and administrative services.

MP0ST

Rupee rises 10 paise to 94.40 against dollar

MUMBAI: The rupee pared its initial losses and settled for the day 10 paise higher at 94.40 against the US dollar, as the US and Iran signed the peace agreement, boosting global market sentiments.

At the interbank foreign exchange, the rupee opened at 94.66 against the US dollar and traded in the range of 94.18-94.71.

Eventually, it settled at 94.40, up 10 paise from its previous close.

On Wednesday, the rupee appreciated 10 paise to close at 94.50 against the US dollar.

PTI



Central Coalfields Limited
“A Miniratna Company”
(A Subsidiary of Coal India Limited)

NOTICE

"All the tenders issued by CIL and its Subsidiaries for procurement of Goods, Works and Services are available on website of Coal India Ltd. www.coalindia.in/ respective Subsidiary Company (CCL, www.centralcoalfields.in/). CIL e-procurement portal <https://coalindiatenders.nic.in> and Central Public Procurement Portal <https://eprocure.gov.in> in addition, procurement is also done through GeM portal <https://gem.gov.in/>".

NORTHERN RAILWAY
OPEN E-TENDER NOTICE

The Divisional Engineer-IV, Northern Railway, Delhi Division for and on behalf of President of India invites E-Tender on prescribed form for the following work. Invitation of tender through E-Tendering (E-Procurement Systems)

Name of work with its location	Providing/Laying 1x450 mm dia DI carrier pipe through 1x600 mm dia MS casing pipe for water/sewerage under Railway track at km. 141/27-29 between JHI-NRW, 1x250 mm dia DI carrier pipe through 400 mm dia MS casing pipe for water/sewerage purpose Under Track at km: 162/3-5 between DHY-NRW and 1x400 mm dia carrier pipe through 600 mm dia MS casing pipe Under Railway Track at km: 162/4-6 between DHY-NRW on DLI-BTI section. (NIT 17-2026-27-W-IV).
Approx. cost of work	₹1,18,10,443.76
Earnest money	₹2,36,200.00
Date and Time of submission of tender and opening of tender	Bidding Start date for work no. Up to 15:00 hrs. On 26.06.2026 opening of e- Tender at 15:00 hrs. on 10.07.2026
Website particulars, published e-tender, notice location etc. complete details of tender can be seen and web site where the tender form can be downloaded	Above tender available on IREPS site i.e. www.ireps.gov.in
No. 128-W/260/Tender Notice/ NIT 17-26-27 -W-IV Date: 17.06.2026	

SERVING CUSTOMER WITH A SMILE 2089/2026

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Raja Singh S/o Balwant R/o E-58, Udai Vihar, Chander Vihar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case registered vide **FIR No. 159/2010 U/S 324/452/506/34 IPC, PS Nihal Vihar Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said accused **Raja Singh** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said **Raja Singh** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Raja Singh of FIR No. 159/2010 U/S 324/452/506/34 IPC, PS Nihal Vihar Delhi** is required to appear before this court (or before me) to answer the complaint on or before the day of **21.07.2026**.

By Order,
Ms. Komal Garg
Judicial Magistrate First Class-03
West District, Room 292
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8119/OD/2026(Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Neeraj W/o Jitender R/o GF, Premises Near Plot No. 73A, Village Goela Khurd, Najafgarh, New Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Ct Case 1750/2024 PS: Chhawla New Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Neeraj** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Neeraj** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Neeraj** accused of **Ct Case 1750/2024 PS: Chhawla New Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Harleen Singh
ASJ Special Electricity, Room No. 609
Dwarka Court, New Delhi

DP/8109/DW/2026 (Court Matter)

सार्वजनिक सूचना

हमके छतरपाल पुत्र श्री लल्लू व श्रीमति किष्ण पत्नी श्री छत्रपाल निवासी प्लॉट नं. 848, गली नं. 6, गंगला एन्क्लेव फार्ड-1 फरीदाबाद हरियाणा के रहने वाले हैं। वैकी हमारा सगा बेटा है व उसकी पत्नी सुबिता हमारी पुत्रवधू है जो कि हमारा कदना नहीं मानते और दिन लड़ाई-झगड़ा करते हैं इसलिए इनको हमने अपनी तमाम चल-अचल संपत्ति से बेरखल कर दिया है। जो भी आज के बाद इन दोनों से कोई भी लेन-देन आदि करता है वह स्वयं जिम्मेदार होगा हमारी कोई निम्मेवारी नहीं होगी।

millenniumpost
CLASSIFIEDS

CHANGE OF NAME

I, **Alvina John Das W/o Sh. Chaitanya Das R/o D-215, G/ F, Back Side, Jhilmil Colony, East Delhi, Delhi- 110095** do declare that my name in my Baptism Certificate is written as **Albina John**, but my name in my Aadhar Card, Pan Card is written as **Alvina John Das**. That both the name i.e. **Alvina John Das** and **Albina John** are the name of one and same person.

EAST CENTRAL RAILWAY

E-tender Notice

E-tender Notice No. 22 of 2026-27 (Open)-Engg/DDU On line (through e-tendering) for the following work is invited by DRM/Engg/DDU for and on behalf of the President of India from experienced and financially as well as technically sound contractors including those enlisted with the Railway. CPWD, BSNL, MES, PWD and other public sector undertakings:- (1) Name of work with its location: Tender No. 10-DDU-SR DEN-III-26-27 Raising and extension of platform and other divyangjan amenities at jipla station. (2) Advertised Value: Rs. 52707232.68 (3) Earnest Money: 1054200.00 (4) Closing Date & time for submission of e-tender: 10.07.2026, Up-to 12:00 hrs. (5) Website particulars of e-tendering: www.ireps.gov.in Divisional Railway Manager E.C. Railway, DDU PR/0402/DDU/ENGG/T/26-27/24

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON

See Section 82(2) (ii) Cr. P.C./84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita Whereas a complaint has been made before me that accused person **Sunny S/o Mahesh Sharma R/o Gali No. 10, Sunday Bazar Road, Nathu Colony, Delhi**, have committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence under **FIR No. 321/2021 U/s 457/380/411/34 IPC.**, has been registered at **P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest there upon issued that the said, **Sunny** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said, **Sunny** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused, **Sunny** of under **FIR No. 321/2021 U/s 457/380/411/34 IPC.**, registered at **P.S. Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **18.08.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Jyoti Nain
JMFC-07 (North), 1st Floor
Room No. 06, Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/7757/ON/2026 (Court Notice)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(SEE SECTION 82(2) (ii) Cr.P.C./84 BNSS)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person(s) **Javed Abbas S/o Fakre Alam R/o B-185, Shankar Niwas, 2nd Floor, Ganga Vihar, Delhi Also At V-721/21, Street No. 18, Vijay Park, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in Case **FIR No. 666/2022, U/s 380/411 IPC, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi** and it has been returned to a Warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused person(s) **Javed Abbas** can not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person(s) **Javed Abbas** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person(s) **Javed Abbas** of Case **FIR No. 666/2022, U/s 380/411 IPC, PS Bhajanpura, Delhi** is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before dated **30.07.2026**.

By Order
Pankaj Rai
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
Room No. 73, 5th Floor
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/7966/NE/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
TENDER NOTICE (Through e-tendering)

Name of work with its location	Provision of Telecom Passenger amenities for new Coaching Terminal at Shakurbasti.
App. Cost of the work (₹)	₹ 2,68,99,873.92/- only
Earnest Money Deposit (₹)	₹ 5,38,000/- only
Address of the office	Senior Divisional Signal & Telecom Engineer-C, Northern Railway, 3 rd Floor, Annexe-1, DRM Office, New Delhi-110055.
Date & Time for upload the tender/closing of tender	Tender uploading / closing date & Time 10.07.2026 up to 15.00 hrs.
Website particular & notice board location where complete details of the tender can be seen etc.	See the Northern Railway website www.ireps.gov.in & Notice board at S&T branch, 3 rd Floor, DRM office, State Entry Road, New Delhi-110055.
Tender No.: 558-Sig-16-Tele-OT-1039 Dated: 17.06.2026 2090/2026	

SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Asif S/o Shahbuddin R/o Vegabond Dargah Nizamuddin, New Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 9/2026 U/s 25/54/49 Arms Act PS: Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Asif** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Asif** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Asif** accused of **FIR No. 9/2026 U/s 25/54/49 Arms Act PS: Hazrat Nizamuddin, New Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **21.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Manoj Kaushal
JMFC-03, Room No. 512
Saket Court, New Delhi

DP/7984/SE/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTHERN RAILWAY
Office of the Principal Chief Materials Manager
Headquarters Office, Baroda House, New Delhi-110001
Mail ID: salenr365@gmail.com

E-AUCTION NOTICE No. 'August-2026'

E-Auction will be conducted for disposal of Ferrous Scrap, Non Ferrous Scrap, Other Misc Scrap, Condemned Loco Coaches and Wagons, Scrap Rail and Other Scrap P.Way material etc. Used Lead Acid Batteries/Used Oil/Refused Oil etc. will be sold only to recyclers registered with State Pollution Control Board. Auction programme is as under:-

E-AUCTION DATES FOR 'AUGUST-2026'							
S. No.	Depot/Division Auction Conducting Unit	Auction Starting Time	1st round date	2nd round date	3rd round date	4th round date	5th round date
1.	Dy. CMM/AMV (0522-2451257)	10:30 AM	5	10	14	20	24
2.	Dy. CMM/SSB (011-27015387)	10:30 AM	6	10	14	19	24
3.	Dy. CMM/JUDW (01732-252388)	10:30 AM	7	12	18	21	25
4.	Sr. DMM/DLI (011-23365311)	10:30 AM	6	11	18	21	25
5.	Sr. DMM/UMB (0171-2611203)	10:30 AM	7	11	17	21	25
6.	Sr. DMM/FZR (01632-244154)	10:30 AM	6	11	17	21	27
7.	Sr. DMM/LKO (0522-2234756)	10:30 AM	5	10	14	20	24
8.	Sr. DMM/MB (0591-2413141)	10:30 AM	6	12	17	24	27

1. The details of item to be sold in auction will be available in catalogue at www.ireps.gov.in. 2. The intending purchasers may inspect the scrap material before the auction during working hours at nominated locations. 3. To participate in e-auction, purchasers need to get themselves registered with ireps. The details on last sold rates in auctions are available at www.railnet.gov.in 4. For further details regarding registration and other conditions of e-auction, please visit website www.ireps.gov.in. (Ankit Gupta)

No.: 117-S/Sale/Auction Programme/2026-27 Date: 16.06.2026 Dy. Chief Material Manager/S&P
SERVING CUSTOMERS WITH A SMILE 2059/2026

SYMBOLIC POSSESSION NOTICE
ICICI Bank

Branch Office: ICICI Bank Limited Plot No-23, Shal Tower, 3rd Floor, New Rohtak Road, Karol Bagh, New Delhi- 110005

The Authorised ICICI Bank Officer under the Securitisation, Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 and in exercise of the powers conferred under section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002, issued Demand Notices to the borrower(s) mentioned below, to repay the amount mentioned in the Notice within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said Notice.

Having failed to repay the amount, the Notice is issued to the borrower and the public in general that the undersigned has taken symbolic possession of the property described below, by exercising powers conferred on him/her under Section 13(4) of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the said rules on the below-mentioned dates. The borrower in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with the property. Any dealings with the property will be subject to charges of ICICI Bank Limited.

Sr. No.	Name of the Borrower(s)/ Loan Account Number	Description of Property/ Date of Symbolic Possession	Date of Demand Notice/ Amount in Demand (Rs)	Name of Branch
1.	Rahul Uniyal/ Indresh Charan Uniyal/ LBDEH00002418443	Unit Bearing No.318 (Without Roof Rights) 3rd Floor, Situated At Times Square Mall, Constructed Over Kharsa No. 308, 309 Ga, 309 Kha, 310, Sahasradhara Road, Vill- Adhoiwala, Pargana Parvadoon, Dist- Dehradun, Uttarakhand- 248001/ 16-Jun-26	February 25, 2026 Rs. 8,74,692.81/-	Dehradun/ New Delhi/ Noida

The above-mentioned borrowers(s)/guarantors(s) is/are hereby issued a 30 day Notice to repay the amount, else the mortgaged properties will be sold after 30 days from the date of publishing this Notice, as per the provisions under Rules 8 and 9 of Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules 2002.

Date: June 19, 2026 Place: New Delhi & Noida Sincerely Authorised Officer, For ICICI Bank Ltd,

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 CrPC

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person **Mahender S/o Ram Singh, R/o H.No. A-371, Ghadoli Dairy Farm, M.V.-III, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No. 195/2011, U/S 395/397/412/120B IPC and FIR No. 141/2011, U/S 25 Arms Act, PS Crime Branch-East, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Mahender** cannot be found, and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Mahender** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant);

Proclamation is hereby made that **Mahender** the said accused of **FIR No. 195/2011, U/S 395/397/412/120B IPC and FIR No. 141/2011, U/S 25 Arms Act, PS Crime Branch-East, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Anurag Thakur
Additional Sessions Judge,
Fast Track Court (East), Court No. 30,
Karkardooma Courts, Delhi

DP/7979/Crime/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused person, **Deepanshu, S/o: Sh. Uttam Chand R/o : H.No 16/648H, Bapa Nagar, Karol Bagh, Delhi**, has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **FIR No.: 422/23, U/s: 356/379/34/411 IPC, P.S.: Karol Bagh, Delhi**, and the warrant has been returned writing upon that the said accused person, **Deepanshu**, cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused person, **Deepanshu**, has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant). Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused person, **Deepanshu**, **FIR No.: 422/23, U/s: 356/379/34/411 IPC, P.S.: Karol Bagh, Delhi**, is required to appear before this court to answer the said complaint on or before **27.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh Nishat Bangarh
Judicial Magistrate First Class-01
(Central), Room No 180
Tis Hazari Court, Delhi

DP/8072/CD/2026 (Court Matter)

DELHI TRANSCO LIMITED
NOTICE INVITING e-TENDERS

Delhi Transco Ltd, a Government of NCT of Delhi Undertaking, invites online tender for the work :

Tender No.T25P131644: special repair to control room building at 220 Kv S/Station Okhla.

For complete details of the tender please visit following websites:- <https://govtprocurement.delhi.gov.in> (Tender ID No. 2026_DTL_293284_1) and www.dtl.gov.in with Unique No. DTL-0049-120626

Last date for bid submission: 22.07.2026 at 13.00 Hrs.

"All corrigendum/ Addendum/ Amendments/ Date of Extensions/ Clarifications etc. to this e-tender will be hosted on the above website only. Bidders should regularly visit website to keep themselves updated.

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused persons Namely (1) **Lucky S/o Dasrath R/o Gureli Gaon Bahar Hat Distt. Nagaon, Assam** (2) **Manish@Mohan S/o Jeevan R/o H. No. 96/10 Multani Dhada Paharganj Delhi** (3) **Manoj Kumar@Rocky S/o Pyare Lal R/o H. No. 11, Gali No. 7, 25 Foota Road, Budh Vihar Ghaziabad UP** (4) **Manoj Kumar S/o Raju Gujrati R/o B-133, JJ Colony, Sauda, PS Kanjhawala Delhi** has committed (or are suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 310/2018 U/s 353/186/34 IPC, PS: Hari Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused (1) **Lucky** (2) **Manish@Mohan** (3) **Manoj Kumar@Rocky** (4) **Manoj Kumar** cannot be found and whereas it have been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused persons (1) **Lucky** (2) **Manish@Mohan** (3) **Manoj Kumar@Rocky** (4) **Manoj Kumar** have absconded (or are concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said (1) **Lucky** (2) **Manish@Mohan** (3) **Manoj Kumar@Rocky** (4) **Manoj Kumar** accused persons of **FIR No. 310/2018 U/s. 353/186/34 IPC, PS: Hari Nagar, Delhi** are required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **29.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Moksha Bains
JMFC-11, Room No, 31
Tis Hazari Court, New Delhi

DP/7999/WD/2026 (Court Matter)

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
E-Tender Notice No.: JHS-N-W-62-26 Date: 16.06.2026

E-Tender Notice

Sr. Divisional Signal & Telecommunication Engineer/ Jhansi, DRM's office, Jhansi, for and on behalf of President of India invite Tender through on Line (E-Tendering) for the following works.

Description of work: Comprehensive annual maintenance of Hitachi make Electronics interlocking at LSC-28, 29, 30, 31, 32, 34, 35, 36, 37, 37A, Babina Auto block MLK II(1), Mataltia Auto Block MLK II (1) & Talbehat MLK II (1) of Jhansi division for a period of three year.

Approx Cost : ₹ 16688803.50 Earnest Money : ₹ 333800/-

Cost of Tender Form :Nil Opening of tender: 08.07.2026 Time 15:00.

Completion period from issue of letter of acceptance: 36 Months.

Tender on line can be submitted upto 15:00 hrs on 08.07.2026. For full details and submission of bid please see the Indian Railways website www.ireps.gov.in. (NORTH CENTRAL RLY/JHANSI DIVISION-SANDT) 1369/26(DG)

[f](#) North central railways [✉](#) @CPRONCR [www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in](#)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Vikash S/o Sukhbir R/o A-56, Gali No-5, Nathu Colony, Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 289/20 U/s 457/380/411/34 IPC PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Vikash** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Vikash** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Vikash** accused of **FIR No. 289/20 U/s 457/380/411/34 IPC PS: Swaroop Nagar, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **23.07.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sahil Gupta
JMFC - 07, Room No - 06,
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8061/ON/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bhartiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita-2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Karan Sharma S/o Yudhister Sharma R/o D-79, Khyala Phase - I, West Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 470/2025 U/s 33/58 Delhi Excise Act PS: Mangolpuri, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Karan Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Karan Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Karan Sharma** accused of **FIR No. 470/2025 U/s 33/58 Delhi Excise Act PS: Mangolpuri, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **31.07.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Reetika Jain
JMFC-05, Room No, 105
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8125/OD/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C.

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **Pulkit Sharma S/o Satish Sharma R/o H. No. 54 Near G.T. Road Delhi Gate Ghaziabad U.P.** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No. 13/2011 U/s 498A/406/34 IPC PS: Keshav Puram, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Pulkit Sharma** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Pulkit Sharma** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Pulkit Sharma** accused of **FIR No. 13/2011 U/s 498A/406/34 IPC PS: Keshav Puram, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.12.2026**.

By Order
Ms. Neha Goel
JMFC (Mahila Court)-02, Room No.18
Ground Floor, Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8016/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 82 Cr.P.C./84 BNSS

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused person Namely **M/s AIOC Through Its Prop. Sh. Soham Biswas R/o H. No. 2997, Main Road, Old Bus Stand, Tri Nagar, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in **Case Reg No. 15924/2019 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Keshav Puram, Delhi**, and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Sh. Soham Biswas** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Sh. Soham Biswas** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Sh. Soham Biswas** accused of **Case Reg No. 15924/2019 U/s 138 NI Act PS: Keshav Puram, Delhi**, is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **25.08.2026**.

By Order
Sh. Sanyam Jain
JMFC-04, Room No. 112, 1st Floor
Rohini Court, Delhi

DP/8011/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
See Section 84 Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita, 2023

Whereas complaint has been made before me that the accused **Naushad Khan, S/o. Anwar Ali, R/o.: A4/79, Block A, Pocket Sector-17 Rohini, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in a case vide Case **FIR No.537/2025 Dated 20/11/2025 U/S 318(4)/316(2)/351(2) BNS** registered at **P.S. Ashok Vihar, NorthWest District, Delhi** and it has been returned on a warrant of arrest there upon issued stating that the said accused **Naushad Khan** could not be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that accused **Naushad Khan** is absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said **Naushad Khan**, accused of Case **FIR No.537/2025 Dated 20/11/2025 U/S 318(4)/316(2)/351(2) BNS, P.S. Ashok Vihar, NorthWest District, Delhi** is required to appear before the court to answer the said complaint on or before **28.07.2026**.

By Order, **Ms. Upasana Satija,**
Chief Judicial Magistrate (North West)
Court No.106, First Floor,
Rohini Courts, Delhi

DP/8177/NW/2026 (Court Matter)

PROCLAMATION REQUIRING THE APPEARANCE OF ACCUSED PERSON
(See Section 82 Cr.PC)

Whereas complaint has been made before me that accused **Akbar, S/o Mohd. Akram R/o D-63, Rajadhani Park 40 Futa Road, Nangloi, Delhi** has committed (or is suspected to have committed) the offence in case **FIR No.54/2021 u/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** and it has been returned to a warrant of arrest thereupon issued that the said accused **Akbar** cannot be found and whereas it has been shown to my satisfaction that the said accused **Akbar** has absconded (or is concealing himself to avoid the service of the said warrant).

Proclamation is hereby made that the said accused **Akbar** of **FIR No.54/2021 u/s 356/379/411/34 IPC, P.S. Paschim Vihar West, Delhi** is required to appear before this Court to answer the said complaint on or before **05.08.2026**.

By Order,
Sh. Ankit Karan Singh
Metropolitan Magistrate-08, West
Room No.30, Tis Hazari Courts, New Delhi

DP/8082/OD/2026

NORTH CENTRAL RAILWAY
Letter No.:- DRMC/AGRA/NFR/E-AUCTION Dated:- 16.06.2026
NOTICE INVITING E-AUCTION

On Behalf of The President of India, The Sr. Divisional Commercial Manager, North Central Railway -Agra invites E-Auction as per categories given as under:-

Category:	Misc-Static-Services	Auction Catalogue No.:	NFR-AGRA-26-07
Asset Details		E-Auction Start Date and Time	E-Auction End Date and Time
Battery Operated Cart at Idgah Jn. Railway Station.		Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:00	Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:30
Installation & Operation of Water Vending Machine (WVM) at Dholpur Railway Station.		Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:10	Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:40
Installation & Operation of Water Vending Machine (WVM) at Idgah Jn. Railway Station.		Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:20	Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:50
Installation & Operation of Water Vending Machine (WVM) at Kosi kalan Railway Station.		Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 11:30	Date:- 29.06.2026 Time:- 12:00

Note:- Prospective bidders are requested to visit E-Auction Leasing Module on IREPS website (www.ireps.gov.in). The Lot-wise details are available therein under the above mentioned Catalogue Number. 1363/26(A)

[f](#) North central railways [✉](#) @CPRONCR [www.ncr.indianrailways.gov.in](#)

Hurri Kane strikes Croatia

Kane ties England's record for World Cup goals in 4-2 win over Croatia

KANSAS CITY: Hey, Jude, you and Harry didn't let England down.

Harry Kane scored twice to equal the English record for World Cup goals, and Jude Bellingham put England in front for good two minutes into the second half of a 4-2 victory over Croatia on Wednesday.

Martin Baturina and Petar Musa answered each of Kane's first-half goals in a rematch of a 2018 semifinal won by Croatia. Musa's goal came on the final play before the whistle ending the first half.

The even score didn't last long once play resumed.

Bellingham took a long pass from Elliot Anderson and stayed clear of the defender the rest of the way, sending a shot past Dominik Livakovic and in off the far post. Marcus Rashford padded the lead in the 85th minute.

"He just told us to let the shackles off," Kane said of coach Thomas Tuchel's halftime message after Croatia pulled even so late before the break. "The way we conceded that second goal is not the team we want to be. He finally just said, 'What's the worst that can happen? We lose the match, first group game, we get on with it.' We move on. Just go and kind of show the world who we can be."



Harry Kane equalled Gary Lineker with 10 goals overall; BELOW: Luis Diaz starred in Colombia's win

Kane, who won the Golden Boot at the 2018 World Cup in Russia by scoring six times, is up to 10 World Cup goals, tying Gary Lineker's mark from the 1986 and 1990 tournaments.

The 32-year-old's first goal came on his second chance on a penalty kick after Livakovic's save on the first try was nullified by a video review that showed both his feet off the goal line as Kane was striking the ball.

Kane went the same way toward the right post with the



second attempt, while Livakovic lunged the other direction, to his right. The penalty was called when Luka Modric, the 40-year-old midfielder who

2

Kane became just the second England player to score at three separate World Cup tournaments

extended his Croatian record by appearing in his fifth World Cup, kicked Noni Madueke in the thigh.

Diaz dazzles MEXICO CITY: Colombia arrived at the World Cup with dreams of redemption after missing out on Qatar in 2022. Although it was tense at times, the Cafeteros got off to a strong start.

Luis Diaz had a goal and an assist in his debut on soccer's biggest stage, sparking Colombia to a 3-1 win over Uzbekistan on Wednesday night.

"That's what we came here to do. It's very important to win this first game. We controlled the first half, but they played better in the second," said Diaz, who plays for Bayern Munich. "We must improve." AGENCIES

MOROCCO DEMONS HAUNT

Samba boys under scrutiny as Brazil seek Haiti reset



Brazil's Neymar during a training session

MORRISTOWN: Brazil face Haiti on Friday needing a World Cup reset rather than another misty-eyed reminder of their glittering past, after a disappointing Group C draw with Morocco left Carlo Ancelotti's side with bruises, questions and little room for another flop.

The five-time champions were rescued in their opener by a flash of brilliance from Vinicius Jr, who dragged Brazil level after Ismael Saibari gave Morocco an early lead in a first half that left them pinned back and short of ideas.

Morocco, Africa Cup of Nations champions and one of the major surprise packages of the 2022 World Cup in Qatar, looked sharper, braver and more coherent for long spells,

leaving Brazil relieved to escape with a point. Now comes Haiti in Philadelphia, a match Brazil will be expected to win but one that arrives with thorns attached.

Haiti, among the tournament's major underdogs, began with a 1-0 defeat by Scotland, but Brazil's most awkward opponent may be their own uncertainty.

Ancelotti was criticised for starting striker Igor Thiago and right back Roger Ibanez against Morocco, while midfielders Casemiro and Lucas Paqueta struggled badly before halftime. The introduction of Danilo, Fabinho and Matheus Cunha after the break brought more balance and energy, handing the Italian coach a familiar tournament puzzle. AGENCIES

FIH PRO LEAGUE

India pass Germany as Manpreet hits milestone

ROTTERDAM: Manpreet Singh became the most capped player with his 413th appearance as India defeated Germany 3-1 while producing a strong defensive display in their second match of the FIH Hockey Pro League here.

Mandeep Singh (7th), Shilanand Lakra (13th) and Nilakanta Sharma (35th) netted one goal each for India while Raphael Hartkopf (45th) pulled one back for the hosts.

Indian midfielder Hardik Singh was adjudged the Player of the Match. India began with controlling ball possession

Women beat Uruguay

AUCKLAND: India bounced back after conceding an early goal to beat Uruguay 3-2 and finish at the top of Pool A in the FIH Women's Nations Cup New Zealand, here on Thursday.

Deepika netted twice while Deepika Soreng found the back of the net once as India recorded a third consecutive victory in the tournament, having earlier defeated USA and Japan. USA finished second and joined India in the semifinals. AGENCIES

which lead to the first goal in the seventh minute when Mandeep executed a sharp turn in front of the goal to give his side a 1-0 lead. Before the end of the first quarter, Lakra beat the

German goalkeeper Alexander Stadler with a fine strike to put India 2-0 ahead.

Germany tried to push deep in the opposition's half in the second quarter but the

Indian defence remain solid. Germany won two penalty corners thereon, but the first was blocked well by Amit Rohidas and the second was thwarted by goalkeeper Mohith to keep India's lead intact. India extended their lead to 3-0 when Nilakanta took on the German defenders in a solo run and slotted the ball into the goal. With just 20 seconds left in the third quarter, Hartkopf scored the first goal for his side in the 45th minute. But despite their increased tempo and efforts to push hard, the Germans could not add more to tally. AGENCIES

Back in action, Neeraj set for Pathirage challenge

DOHA: Indian javelin throw superstar Neeraj Chopra would hope that his lengthy injury-forced absence from competition does not affect his rhythm when he returns to action against an in-form line-up of heavyweight rivals in the familiar environs of the Doha Diamond League here on Friday.

The top-class field here would include rising Sri Lankan star Rumesch Tharanga Pathirage, who surpassed the 90m mark a few days ago.

The 28-year-old Chopra, on the other hand, has been recuperating from a back injury which has prevented him from competing since the World



Neeraj Chopra has assured that he "feels fit"

Championships in September last year. He had finished eighth in that event with a below-par throw of 84.03m, but he will be hoping to hit his stride straightaway at the Qatar Sports Club. Doha has been his happy

hunting ground. It was here that the two-time Olympic medallist breached the coveted 90m mark in May last year. He had recorded 90.23m to finish second behind Julian Weber (91.06m) of Germany.

It was to be originally held on May 8 as the season-opening event but was postponed due to the West Asia conflict.

Chopra, who has been training in Switzerland since May 25 after a rehabilitation stint in Türkiye, was a late addition to the nine-man field.

"I started throwing one and a half months ago and we took our time. Then I asked Doha (organisers) if it's possible if I let them know (about taking part in Doha DL) in very short period, like one week ago. They said yes and then we decided after my last session, okay let's compete in Doha," Chopra said. AGENCIES

Leisure

‘Didn’t want work that triggered me’

Sonali Bendre said she chooses only positive roles after her cancer battle

Sonali Bendre was diagnosed with stage 4 cancer in 2018. After fighting the illness and recovering, she made her comeback in 2022 with a web series called 'The Broken News'. In the same year, she also appeared as a judge on the dance reality show 'DID Li'l Masters'. After her recovery, Sonali consciously decided to avoid dark and heavy roles, as she felt they could drain her emotionally. She was very clear about the kind of work she wanted to take up.

In a conversation with 'News18', she opened up about her mindset, saying, "I really wanted to play hopeful and lighter roles that would've kept me happy through it all and I couldn't come back pepped up. I wanted work like that, especially since I had been through a really dark period. I was coming out of it and didn't want to do work that would trigger me and make me spiral. It was such a fun film ('Love Ke Liye Kuch Bhi Karega'). The amount of fun Saif Ali Khan and I had shooting for it! The energy was great on set. There are very few good, fun and light-hearted stories like that which were being written."

Interestingly, her latest show, 'Raakh', which is a dark and intense watch, was never on her list. But the project came to her and she couldn't say no.

"'Raakh' wasn't something I was looking for. I wasn't open to it, but it came my way. It just goes to show how compelling the content was. The script was so amazing and so was my character and the entire team involved. There was no way I could've said no to it. I hope I keep getting stuff like 'Raakh', stuff I can't say no to. I do hope more creators and directors see me as someone that people usually don't see me as. I really didn't think people were seeing me for roles like this one. Every time I felt I wasn't being seen that way, somebody was. It took some time, but I'm glad it came to me," Sonali shared. AGENCIES

‘Babu is a mixture of multiple animals’



Ramandeep Yadav and Akash Makhija essay Rajjo and Babu in the haunting investigative thriller 'Raakh'

OUR CORRESPONDENT

One of the most challenging aspects of Prime Video's haunting investigative thriller 'Raakh' was crafting characters who are deeply flawed yet psychologically authentic. For Ramandeep Yadav and Akash Makhija, bringing Rajjo and Babu to life required looking beyond the violence their roles commit and uncovering the emotional and psychological truths that shape their choices. Through intensive workshops, character-building exercises and extensive creative discussions, both actors immersed themselves in the inner worlds of their characters, approaching them not as villains, but as fully realised individuals shaped by their circumstances, convictions and beliefs.

Reflecting on his process of bringing Rajjo to life, Ramandeep shared, "I come from a theatre background, where building a character takes time, observation and a deeper understanding of the person you are portraying. 'Raakh' gave me the space and time to gradually shape the character and understand his mindset without rushing the process. My approach was always to humanise the character, not make him look

like a hero or a villain. I also realised that while performing, you have to keep your personal judgement aside and stay truthful to the character's reality. The workshops and discussions with the team helped all of us develop the character's emotional and psychological layers more authentically."

Speaking about his approach to portraying Babu, Akash revealed, "I was given this very beautiful insight that Babu is a mixture of multiple animals. He can be a snake, a tiger, a fox - it all depends on the situation. I used those instincts in every scene. Another insight that really stayed with me was that it's Babu's world and everyone else is living in it. He doesn't think by society's rules or morality. In his mind, he's never wrong. That helped me understand how someone like Babu justifies his actions to himself and commits those crimes without guilt. I didn't want to approach him as a villain. Prosit sir and I were very clear that he had to feel like a real person, someone who exists within society and blends into the world around us. For me, that's what makes a character like Babu truly frightening - the idea that he could be anyone, someone you might pass by every day without ever knowing what's beneath the surface."